Fragile Links?
Variability in Identity Content and its Implications for Group Cohesion

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Abstract

Explanations of group voting behavior often emphasize the strength of individuals' group attachments. While straightforward, this explanation is incomplete, omitting an important requirement for political cohesion: consensual group meaning. Such identity content highlights group membership's political implications and is thought to come from exposure to the expectations around group membership seen in group embeddedness. Focusing on race and Blacks' and Latinos' political opinions, we link group embeddedness to identity content, operationalized as linked fate, using data spanning 2016-2024 from the American National Election Study and Collaborative Multiracial Postelection Study. While group embeddedness does increase linked fate, heteroskedastic regression models show that it does not always encourage endorsement consistency, with this varying across groups and elections. Uncertainty in group meaning increases opinion variability on key outcomes that strict attention to identity strength misses. By highlighting stressors of group cohesion, understanding contingencies in identity content helps better explain group-based political behavior.

Paper Prepared for the 2026 Elections, Public Opinion, and Voting Behavior Meeting

In 2024, Donald Trump received 15% of Black Americans' votes, up from 8% in 2020, and 48% of Hispanic Americans', up from 36% in 2020 (Hartig et al. 2025). These shifts in the voting behavior of people of color in 2020 and 2024 have raised important questions about the link between racial identification and political preferences. Given the hypervigilance most individuals in marginalized and stigmatized groups place on improving their status, and the chronic salience of these group attachments when contrasted with those of the majority group (Pérez and Vicuña 2023), what accounts for Donald Trump's gains with these groups? Explanations variously point to the increased relevance of ideological concerns, material interests, beliefs about the racial hierarchy, or other group identities (Alamillo 2019; Brown et al 2024; Castro-Irizarry 2026; Fraga, Velez, and West 2025; Geiger and Reny 2024; Pérez 2024). While all possible, they imply a reduction in concern with one's group and its political status, or in other words a "declining significance of race." But data from the American National Election Study reveal little change in the importance people of color place on their racial or panethnic attachments since 2012.[1] If anything, 2020 and 2024 saw an *increase* in the proportion of group members saying their racial background was "extremely important" to who they are as a person compared to 2012. How can stable commitments to one's racial group coincide with this evidence for voting on the basis of concerns that seemingly run counter to group interests?

We argue that identity content is an omitted moving part in these accounts. Identity content helps people answer the question of "Who am I?" by informing them on what it means culturally, socially, and, important for our purposes, politically to be a part of a group (Abdelal et al 2006; Abrams 1992; Deaux 1993; Huddy 2001). To the degree group members share common understandings of their group's constructed meaning, then those identifying with the group should have similar beliefs and behavioral tendencies and the group behaves more cohesively. But just as

[1] "How important is being RACE to your identity?" scaled 0 (not at all) to 1 (extremely).
Asian: ($\bar{x}_{2012} = .56; \bar{x}_{2016} = .64;\ \bar{x}_{2020} = .65;\ \bar{x}_{2024} =..62$), Black: ($\bar{x}_{2012} = .77; \bar{x}_{2016} = .81;\ \bar{x}_{2020} = .82;\ \bar{x}_{2024} = .77$), Latino: ($\bar{x}_{2012} = .63; \bar{x}_{2016} = .66;\ \bar{x}_{2020} = .66;\ \bar{x}_{2024} = .63$).

Americans disagree over what constitutes "good" citizenship and partisans disagree about what defines appropriate beliefs (Huddy and Khatib 2007; Pérez, Deichert, and Engelhardt 2019; Schildkraut 2010, 2014; Blum 2020; Sniderman and Stiglitz 2012), so, too, can individuals in a racial group vary in what they think group identification requires. Group membership may provide cultural meaning for some while for others it implies political action, with this varying further still by action via conventional means or alternative paths (Anoll 2022; Masuoka 2007) as well as what issues it implies a particular political stance on (Brown and Shaw 2002; Dawson 2001; Hickel et al 2021; Pérez 2015a). The more diverse the meanings members ascribe to the group, the more heterogenous members' opinions and behaviors will be.

Accounts describing the path to group politicization and the degree of group cohesion clarify the importance of considering identity content. Multiple processes must occur before an identity's meaning becomes political (Junn 2006; Lee 2008). This includes the development of group consciousness, where group identification becomes linked with group-based grievances related to systemic problems (Miller, Gurin, Gurin and Malanchuk 1981; Jardina 2019; Simon and Klandermans 2001). Consciousness then facilitates political cohesion when group members place the responsibility for solving these problems at the feet of the government (Iyengar 1991; Junn 2006; Lee 2008).

While existing work elaborates on the attitudinal and contextual factors leading to group cohesion and politicization, it leaves unaddressed the extent to which these outlooks are held in common (Abdelal et al 2006; Simon and Klandermans 2001). In other words, how homogenous or heterogenous are the political consequences group members believe their identification entails? Research indicates that group identification precedes group consciousness (e.g., Dawson 1994; Jardina 2019; Lee 2008; Pérez et al 2024), but how reliably do two people similarly invested in their group have the same interpretation of group interests? They may both see a lot of discrimination against their group, but only one may map these perceptions onto a belief that these experiences require systemic solutions. Alternatively, they may both map these perceptions onto a belief that their experiences require systemic solutions, but disagree about the best one. While group identification promotes cohesion in opinion and action when group meaning is consensual, the political effects of these same commitments become heterogenous in light of conflict which makes an identity's total effects for the whole group fragile.

Focusing on Black and Latino Americans, we use multiple nationally representative data sets to explore the extent to which group members predisposed to care about their group's position agree on how best to address this. We first probe how variation in group embeddedness—a metric capturing the degree of individual exposure to the norms, interests, prototypes, and perceived relational context promoting group meaning (Anoll 2022; Anoll, Davenport, Lienesch 2025; Dawson 1994; Harris-Lacewell 2006; Strawbridge 2025; Wong et al 2020)—contributes to whether group members attach any political meaning, and the same political meaning, to their group. Operationalizing identity content as linked fate, estimates from a heteroskedastic regression model show that the more embedded one is in their racial group, the more linked fate they express. However, we find that the degree to which embeddedness uniformly encourages increased linked fate is conditional (e.g. Alvarez and Brehm 2002; Franklin 1989; Hutchings, McClerking, and Charles 2004). We find that group embeddedness can promote consistency in linked fate endorsement, but not always. We then identify behavioral manifestations consistent with our argument about the consequences of variability in group meaning. Uncertainty in identity content manifests in varying levels of cohesion in group members' votes and their views of political figures.

Our results suggest that while there is some "declining significance of race" on political attitudes and behavior in recent elections, more important to understanding group political cohesion is the heterogeneity introduced by variable *implications* of group attachments. By theorizing about how embeddedness promotes understandings of group meaning, which in turn influence political decisions, we can better explain how we can observe differences over time in a group's political opinions and behaviors even as members' overall attachment to their group remains stable (Pérez and Cobian 2024). Attention to not just how specific factors predispose people toward embracing a specific interpretation of an identity's content, but also the degree to which group members similar on these predisposing factors actually share the same political outlook, helps us better understand the conditional, and uncertain, nature of the identity-to-politics link and subsequent group cohesion.

Agreement and Disagreement in an Identity's (Political) Content

Identity content develops "over time and across situations as a function of cultural and historical factors" (Huddy 2002, 828), with group norms, prototypes and leaders, shared interests, and the relational context contributing to how people think about the groups to which they belong (Abdelal et al 2006; Huddy 2013). Norms establish a group's values, describing what good group members currently, or ought, to do and believe. Similarly, prototypes, a driving force in the self-categorization approach to social identity (Turner et al 1987), inform members on what characteristics, beliefs, and actions define typical members. While norms and prototypes focus more on intragroup processes, shared interests and the relational context link the intergroup setting to meaning. Group identification for some might imply concern with material or symbolic interests, or for others the desire for group aggrandizement broadly construed (Sniderman and Hagendoorn 2007). These interests' valence comes from the relational context, with the group's relative position directing its goals (Craig and Philips 2023; Pérez and Vicuña 2023).

Exposure to the forces underpinning identity content varies. Broadly, the more embedded or immersed someone is in their group, the more likely they will encounter the norms, interests, prototypes, and perceived relational context. Participating in shared social spaces like churches or neighborhood shops (Dawson 1994; Harris-Lacewell 2006), consuming media from indigenous institutions (Strawbridge 2025), or living around coethnics all provide opportunities for exposure to these ideas (Anoll 2022; Wong et al 2020). Similarly, people vary in how much they feel they have in common with others in-group members and thus seek out content offering information on these bonds (Leach et al 2008). But critically, degree of immersion varies across social, geographic, and psychological scales (Anoll, Davenport, Lienesch 2025). The chance one is exposed to information regarding identity content thus varies with group embeddedness.

While variation in exposure in general is important, more important is the nature of the information received. Norms and interests, prototypes and relational contexts can converge, promoting more cohesive understanding of group meaning, or diverge, fragmenting identity content such that group members can dispute or adopt select attributes. When divergent, the meaning of the group identity depends on how individuals differentially value the norms and interests, prototypes, and/or group aggrandizement in, sometimes distinct, political, social, and economic spheres. Identity content, as Abdelal and colleagues (2006) describe, "is the outcome of a process of social contestation within the group" (700). At the individual level, conflict between the factors underpinning group meaning can produce inconsistent outlooks across members of the same group, much like ambivalence or uncertainty can lead to instability in public opinion (Alvarez and Brehm 2002; Zaller and Feldman 1992). Despite a shared recognition of marginality, some group members may conform to dominant group norms while others strive for differentiation (Jefferson 2023), choices abetted by the multiple ways people can identify with the group (Leach et al 2008). Similarly, while group leaders can help reconcile these conflicts, not all members respond uniformly to leaders' messaging (Cohen 1999; Harris-Lacewell 2006; Laird 2019). Therefore, the more consistently contextual and individual factors align on what group membership implies, the more agreement we should see on the content of the group identity, a result promoting political cohesion. But at the same time, the more these forces push against each other, the more likely we will observe inconsistency in meaning. In this case, countervailing effects of group membership will obscure important heterogeneity in how group members map meaning to political outcomes. While the factors promoting specific interpretations of group membership persist, how much these point all group members in the same direction can vary in important ways that existing literature on group-based political behavior ignores.

Our basic model is this: people are immersed in their in-groups to varying degrees. This immersion, in turn, exposes people to information on what it means to be a part of the group, and it is this information that helps explain whether and how people think and act politically. By understanding how much people agree on what it means to be a part of the group, we can better understand what sorts of information they may have received, with implications for their politics.

While this follows conventional models of identities' political relevance, we acknowledge a potential reverse path we cannot fully rule out. People with a given interpretation of their group memberships may have a particular desire to be embedded in their group; meaning precedes embeddedness. While possible, we think our proposed path more likely because identity content fluctuates much more than specific categories or people's memberships in, or attachments to, them (e.g., Abdelal et al 2006). The forces promoting embeddedness are much more closely aligned with people's everyday than is identity content which is much more situationally driven (Pérez and Cobian 2024). But even if this reverse path exists, our focus here is on the transmission of messages about group membership and the consequences for identity content maintenance.

Why Group Political Meaning Should be Consensual

Insights from social identity theory (SIT) and self-categorization theory (SCT), coupled with the nature of contemporary politics, suggest that consensus should define the political content of membership in a marginalized racial group. Psychological approaches to identity emphasize two moving parts in explaining group-based responses: group threat and group investment. Group interests, one of the moving parts in explaining identity content, crystallize under threat (Branscomb et al 1999; Stephan and Stephan 2000). Potential shifts in material (Key 1949; Bobo 1999) or symbolic (Craig and Richeson 2014) standing raise the possibility of social change and the utility of future group-based action to promote or prevent these shifts, a key component of politicized identity content (Miller et al. 1981). Furthermore, the most invested in the group are those most likely to respond to such group-based challenges or opportunities (Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 2002). Motivated to address the group's station, investment predisposes individuals to work toward common aims (Leach et al 2008).

That marginalized groups generally, and racial minorities in particular, have worked politically to improve their station implies a common outlook among group members today to see themselves as interdependent and politics as a venue for action. Beginning in the 1920s, electoral incentives increased the influence Black Americans had on state-level and Congressional Democrats. These changes underpinned the eventual racial realignment brought along by the Civil Rights movement's ability to activate public opinion (Carmines and Stimson 1989; Grant 2020; Lee 2002; Schickler 2016). These dual processes have made normative among Black Americans supporting the Democratic Party and participating politically (Anoll 2022; Morris, Hatchett, and Brown 1989; White and Laird 2020). Likewise, political concerns contributed to formalizing Hispanic pan-ethnicity (Mora 2014), with subsequent treatment by the state promoting group-based political unity (Maltby et al 2020; Roman 2023; White 2016).

Contemporary secular and political trends similarly encourage a sense of interdependence around group norms and interests, especially by making salient the group's relative social standing. Media coverage increasingly features identity-related content, driven in part by consumer demand (Hopkins, Lelkes, and Wolken 2025). Additionally, recent social movement activism has increased attention to the concerns of many Latino and Black Americans and provided perspectives promoting collective action (Dunivin et al 2022; Mendelsohn et al 2024). Likewise, elite rhetoric can mobilize public opinion around group interests (Laird 2019; Lee 2002; Nelson and Kinder 1995; Stephens-Dougan 2020; White 2007). Political parties commonly target communication to voters on the basis of race, with the candidacies of Barack Obama, Donald Trump, and Kamala Harris all raising, in different ways, the relevance of racial identity for political action. Indeed, Kamala Harris's viral "You exist in the context of all in which you live and what came before you" comment spoke directly to her understanding the cultural and historical forces underpinning the interests of marginalized communities (Cohen 2024). These contextual, consciousness-raising efforts make relevant identifiers' understandings of group disadvantage while also promoting political cohesion as important for achieving some collective ends (Pérez 2015b; Rogers and Kim 2023).

That evidence accumulated over decades points to a connection between racial identity and politics likewise suggests consensus among group members on how to engage politically. Racial divides in public opinion are the norm (e.g., Kinder and Winter 2001), with divides starker still after measuring identification instead of coarse group membership (e.g., Jardina 2019; Pérez et al 2019). Similarly, while early research suggested Black Americans were unique among people of color in displaying meaningful partisan attachments (Hajnal and Lee 2011), subsequent research finds heightened partisan stability among Asian and Latino Americans during Trump's first term (Hopkins, Kaiser, and Pérez 2023; McCann and Jones-Correa 2020). Underscoring likely consensual group meaning, Huddy, Mason, and Horwitz (2016) point to how perceived discrimination links Latino identity to Democratic Party identification: partisan identification reflects group political interdependence (see also Pérez 2015b; Kuo, Malhora, and Mo 2017; Maxwell, Pérez, and Zonszein 2023; Pérez, Lee, and Martír 2025; Saavedra 2017).

Together, this evidence suggests that contemporary politics and society in the United States is structured such that the implications of group membership are clear, with consensus characterizing the political implications of group membership for identifiers. This produces our *agreement hypothesis*: racial group embeddedness corresponds with consensus on the identity's political content, on the political implications of group identification.

Why Group Political Meaning Should be Heterogenous

Another reading of these same ideas raises the potential for considerable variability in identity content, with conflict characterizing the potential political connotations of group membership. While threats do crystallize group interests, SIT and SCT also inform us that *how* people respond to these threats depends on the context (Garcia-Rios et al 2019). Individuals' racial contexts differ in important ways, which makes such variability likely (Anoll et al 2025). Collective action seen in political solidarity is more likely in environments where the realization of group interests is possible, which is not always the case (Branscombe et al 1999; Ellemers et al 2002). Racial minorities also experience marginalization on multiple dimensions, with interests around collective action potentially crystallized on some dimensions rather than the others (Zou and Cheryan 2017; Pérez and Kuo 2021). Prototypes can vary, too, with shared meaning undercut as identifiers dispute normatively appropriate behavior (Ellemers and Jetten 2013; Turner et al 1987; Waldzus et al 2004). Group members might have a better understanding about what group interests are in the face of threat, but unified responses need not follow.

This heterogeneity is perhaps best seen in varied beliefs among group members who already see politics as a venue for improving the group's station. Black Americans exhibit important differences in ideological outlook despite their longstanding marginal position (Dawson 2001; Brown and Shaw 2002; Harris-Lacewell 2006) and disagree about the meaning behind political categories like conservative and liberal (Philpot 2017; Jefferson 2024). Expectations about group interdependence and the appropriateness of different political solutions appears linked to variation in socialization across generations (Smith 2014; Smith, Lopez Bunyasi, and Smith 2019), with lifecycle changes in the importance people place on their racial identities capable of further modulating this (Verkuyten et al 2024).

Such limitations are particularly acute for groups like Latinos. The category's comparatively recent appearance, diversity, and persistent connection to stigmatized members via debates over undocumented immigration can undercut a shared political outlook (Beltrán 2010; Garcia Bedolla 2005; Pérez 2016). That some individuals may even shift their racial identities to fit their political commitments underscores potential heterogeneity in how group members interpret the political connotations of group membership; varied political outlooks facilitate increased variability in group identification (Agadjanian and Lacy 2021; Egan 2020).

External actors can exacerbate heterogeneity in group meaning, with the coalition-building and coalition-maintaining efforts of electoral politics potentially promoting conflictual identity content. Lacking elite mobilization, group members may not understand available political opportunities (Lee 2002; Hajnal and Lee 2011; Harris-Lacewell 2006; Silber Mohammed 2017). Political parties' incentives to mobilize different racial groups vary across elections and geographies, making race-based electioneering and political incorporation contingent (Fraga 2018; Frymer 1999). Even with regular mobilization, racial minorities do not always see clear benefits from political participation, a result fostering for some a sense of racial resignation and cynicism with the political system that promotes disagreement over the group's best course of action (Phoenix 2020; Hajnal 2020; Phoenix and Chan 2024).

Evidence consistent with conflict over a racial identity's content likewise manifests in studies of its political relevance. The very normative appropriateness of partisanship for Black Americans, for instance, depends on the potential for social sanction (White and Laird 2020). Evidence for shifts in Latino voting behavior between 2016 and 2020 related to polarization on education and ideology offers additional support (Fraga, Velez, and West 2025). Even among those invested in their racial group, political choice for minorities often depends on balancing their racial identity with other group attachments (Carter 2019; Castro-Irizarry 2026; Pérez et al 2019; Pérez et al 2025; Simien 2005). These other factors' salience suggests identity content varies across group members, even among those viewing the group as important to them and caring about its well-being.

This second perspective emphasizes the complexity of United States politics and the contingent relevance of racial identity. Even those concerned with their group's status may not agree that politics is the appropriate venue or that a specific course of political action offers the best choice. This yields our second, *disagreement hypothesis*: group embeddedness promotes conflict over group meaning, increasing variability across members on the political implications of group membership. As group identifiers seek out ways to address the group's position, they come to different conclusions about appropriate courses of action.

The Conditioning Role of Context

While these hypotheses drive our analyses, we find important tying together an additional thread underpinning them: the importance of context. Context in our argument manifests in two ways: the characteristics of the groups considered and the nature of the political climate in which people negotiate the implications of group membership. Group differences follow from divergent political histories with these fostering or inhibiting shared outlooks around the group's political meaning. To probe the relevance of these shared histories for identity content we test our hypotheses separately for Black and Latino Americans. Doing so holds constant marginality, something that including white Americans would occlude, with this marginality for Blacks and Latinos shared in some respects and divergent in others (Zou and Cheryan 2017). It also allows us to contrast a group more incorporated into the political system, in Black Americans, with one less so, in Latinos, which has implications for the time these groups have had available to negotiate conflict over the identity's political content.

Black Americans provide a place to more likely find evidence for the *agreement hypothesis*. Black racial identity, and subsequently political behavior, is shaped through long-standing group institutions. Media institutions, civic organizations, and churches all provide a strong sense of what it means to be Black in America (Harris-Lacewell 2006; Strawbridge 2025). Dawson (1994) has argued that these meso-level factors bolster a sense of group interdependence (see also Rogers and Kim 2023; Dawson 2001). But these institutions may be losing their influence, suggesting more disagreement (e.g., Cox 2025; Hatfield and Anderson 2024). Even so, White and Laird (2020) elaborate on the importance of social network ties to ideas about normative group behavior, with these more diffuse connections potentially making up for declining physical spaces and promoting agreement.

Latino Americans, in contrast, have a history suggesting more potential for the *disagreement hypothesis* to hold. While the designation Hispanic brought with it specific political content (Mora 2014), the category's relatively recent appears, and the varied interests of people it incorporates, has led to questions about its unifying capacity (Beltrán 2010). Similarly, comparatively few formal entities exist that promote panethnic attachments in particular, making Latinos' day-to-day experiences more often align with national origin. These experiences are also cross-cut by substantial variation in how far individuals are from the immigration experience. While an increasingly similar bloc (Pérez and Cobian 2024), Latinos still display less unity than Black Americans with potential implications for how they understand the content of this identity.

Attending to the political climate likewise takes seriously the potential import of the information environment campaign contexts create. Electoral content can privilege racial or non-racial issues, depending on the prevailing circumstances (Vavreck 2009). We thus test our hypotheses across multiple elections to probe the potential importance of elite mobilization, salient issues, and other similar factors in crystallizing group interests. Doing so allows us, albeit indirectly, to consider some additional meso-level processes important to understanding how some people interpret their membership in a given racial category (Rogers and Kim 2023).

Testing Variability in Group Meaning

We test our hypotheses with data from the 2016, 2020, and 2024 Collaborative Multiracial Post-election Studies (CMPS) and American National Election Studies. The CMPS provides large samples of people of color that, after weighting, approximate the ACS on age, gender, education, nativity, and ancestry.[2] It randomly samples registered and non-registered voters from voter registration and commercial lists, with the interviews self-administered online in multiple languages, including English and Spanish. The ANES in contrast is a national probability sample of U.S. citizens 18 and older with interviews completed with an interviewer or self-administered online, in English or Spanish. In addition to differences in sampling frame and recruitment method, the surveys vary in timing. While all ANES surveys wrapped their post-election waves by the end of December, the CMPS surveys were all completed a couple to several months after the election.[3] These differences in sampling and fielding lead us to see each data set as a separate test of our hypotheses rather than using the ANES to corroborate the CMPS or vice versa. But consistency across each strengthens our belief our results are more general than driven by features of data source like sample or questionnaire.

While we can measure identity content several ways, we operationalize it with linked fate, a common measure of group interdependence that also importantly allows a holistic test across our

[2] Additional information available: https://www.icpsr.umich.edu/web/RCMD/studies/39096/summary and https://www.icpsr.umich.edu/web/ICPSR/studies/38040#

[3] The 2016 survey ran December 2016 through February 2017, the 2020 version ran April through August 2021, and the 2024 iteration ran May to the beginning of September 2025.

several data collections and both groups (McClain et al 2009).[4] Indexing someone's sense that what happens to their ingroup will also happen to them (Dawson 1994, 2001; Tate 1993), linked fate, "best captures the critical cognitive components of racial group consciousness" (McClain et al 2009, 478; see also Chong and Rogers 2005). Building on Dawson's (1994) formulation, scholars have advanced an understanding of linked fate as capturing an awareness of social stratification and the implications of this for someone given their membership in a given group (e.g., Masuoka and Junn 2013; Rogers and Kim 2023). While this perspective has been challenged, with linked fate at least as presently measured not necessarily capturing one's beliefs about their group's social status (Gay, Hochschild, and White 2016), the measure still indexes individuals' sense of interconnectedness and interdependence with other group members, concepts central to our interest in the interface between identity content and group cohesion. That it features in all our data collections makes it part useful. We return to issues of operationalization in the conclusion.

Because our ability to test our hypotheses rests in part on this outcome allowing for disagreement in how people think about their in-group, we use data from the 2016 CMPS to demonstrate that linked fate endorsement is not a univalent concept. One can report feeling that what happens to other group members may happen to them but evaluate this either positively or negatively. In 2016, after respondents answered the linked fate item they then reported whether they feel positively or negatively about the link they have with others in their racial or ethnic group.[5]

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[4] 2016: "Do you think what happens generally to [RACE] people in this country will have something to do with what happens in your life?" If Yes: Will it affect you A lot, Some, Not very much
2020: "How much do you think what happens to the following groups here in the U.S. will have something to do with what happens in YOUR life?" 1 - Nothing to do with what happens; 5- A huge amount to do with what happens.
2024: How much do you think that what happens generally to other [RACE] in this country will affect what happens in your life? 1= A lot, 4= Not at all

[5]"Some people feel positively about the link they have with their racial or ethnic group members, while others feel negatively about the idea that their lives may be influenced by how well the larger

Table 1 shows substantial variation among Black and Latino respondents in how they feel about this interconnectedness and interdependence with other group members. We find that a large share of respondents in each group evaluate these links positively, with potentially the plurality of Latinos but for sampling error. But importantly, variation exists. A similarly large share has no evaluative judgment of these links. But few, we find, evaluate these links negatively – just 8% of Latinos and 9% of Blacks do.

Table 1: How Respondent Feels about Racial/Ethnic Linked Fate

Racial Group	Negatively	Neither	Positively
Black	9%	47%	44%
Latino	8%	44%	47%

Group Embeddedness's Conditional Connection with Variability in Group Meaning

We test our hypotheses about conflict or consensus in identity content by drawing on measures related to the norms, interests, prototype exposure, and relational context underpinning group meaning and that prior work argues divides linked fate perceptions among Blacks and Latinos. We consider: group discrimination, both perceived or experienced (Lu and Jones 2019; Marsh and Ramirez 2019; Masuoka 2006; Sanchez and Masuoka 2010; Sanchez et al 2019); group communication exposure, both general and in-group-specific (e.g., church attendance; consuming ingroup media) (Dawson 1994; Laird 2019); local racial composition, when available (Gay 2004); group identification (Gay, Hochschild, and White 2016); and group status judgments (Dawson 1994).

While these are all distinct constructs, we think that they theoretically offer information on a general dimension of embeddedness (Anoll et al 2025; Strawbridge 2025). We thus construct a single measure of *group embeddedness* or immersion via principal components analysis (PCA) for each survey.

group is doing. Which comes closer to your feelings?" These two response options featured alongside a ``Neither positive or [sic] negative" option.

Given our perspective that consistency relates in part to commonality across sources of group meaning, this statistical model fits our conceptual model that each indicator points toward more group embeddedness (Bollen and Lennox 1991), and that increases or decreases in a given indicator relates to variation in group embeddedness without implying changes in another indicator, an important feature given heterogeneity in how people are immersed in their racial groups (Anoll et al 2025; Strawbridge 2025).[6] While available items vary across surveys, thematic content persists (Appendix A report question wording and measure construction details; Appendix F shows results persist in a leave-one-out test of dimension construction).

We take a similar approach to individual interests. Our aim to understand identity content points to three key indicators: income, education, and, when available, local economic context. We use these to construct an interests measure, via PCA, to array individuals more easily from below to above average in the material and symbolic resources that allow for group exit or promote concern with group values (Dawson 1994; Tate 1993; Enke et al 2022).

We test for conflict and consensus by estimating heteroskedastic regressions. This procedure is advantageous by allowing us to estimate whether model residuals vary systematically with respondent characteristics (e.g., Alvarez and Brehm 2002; Franklin 1989). Support for our *agreement hypothesis* manifests as smaller residuals as group embeddedness increases, consistent with less response variability among the more immersed and, by implication, more group cohesion. Conversely, support for our *disagreement hypothesis* manifests as residuals increasing in size with group embeddedness, with this increased response variability aligning with our claim of greater heterogeneity in responses and more fragmented identity content. If linked fate means the same

[6] We take no position on "true" dimensionality but instead care about capturing variation at the intersection of these several different indicators across individuals, something PCA facilitates.

thing to everyone, embeddedness should lead to uniform endorsement; if not, then variance implies contested meanings.

Our model first follows traditional approaches to explaining linked fate by regressing it on our group embeddedness and individual interests composites as well as controls for sex, age, age squared, and political interest given theories of sex, cohort, and information exposure in developing linked fate (Rogers and Kim 2023; Simien 2005; Smith et al 2019). For Latinos, we also add indicators for generational status and having Mexican ancestry, and for the CMPS analyses we include citizenship status and interview language, given divergent individual trajectories based on language and immigration recency (Sanchez et al 2019). We model the residuals with the same composites as well as political interest to account for its role in response certainty (Alvarez and Brehm 2002).

Table 2 reports our tests of the *agreement* and *disagreement* hypotheses in the ANES and CMPS surveys from 2016 to 2024. We group parameter estimates by racial background and separated by year. Typically, we care about the average effect of variables in a regression. These associations are reported in the top panel which contains the estimated regression coefficients and standard errors for the response equation. But our hypothesis tests attend to noise, with the relevant parameter estimates for the regression's variance equation presented in the bottom panel. A smaller residual (a negative coefficient on embeddedness in this equation) means that highly embedded individuals look similar to one another in how they think about the group's meaning. A larger residual (a positive coefficient on embeddedness) means that as people become more embedded, their outlooks scatter and diverge, indicating disagreement on the group's meaning.

Considering first the result for Black Americans in the 2016 ANES, we see that group embeddedness positively associates with greater linked fate endorsement, consistent with prior work. The difference in average linked fate endorsement for someone at embeddedness's maximum is 62 points greater than someone at linked fate's minimum ($p < .001$). We also find evidence individual interests push the same direction, meaning that higher status Black Americans expressed more linked fate. This average gap is, however, half of that estimated for embeddedness.

But again, our interest is not on direction but on the variability in endorsement, with coefficients for this presented in the variance section. The negative, and significant, coefficient estimate for group embeddedness reveals that moving from the least to most group embedded Black respondent, model residuals decrease in size. This supports our *agreement hypothesis*. More group embedded individuals have more similar model-predicted outcomes than less group embedded individuals. And as the next column shows, we find complementary evidence in the CMPS.

Substantively, the response equation and variance equation tell use several things about Black Americans' understandings of group meaning as manifested in linked fate. The response equation lets us know that increased immersion in the group substantially increases the likelihood that a Black respondent feels connected to other Black Americans. At the same time, the variance equation increases our confidence that Black Americans at a given level of group embeddedness share this sense. The ANES model, for instance, implies that Black respondents particularly embedded in their group (2 standard deviations above the mean) are an average of 33 points apart in linked fate, a divide increasing to 80 points for those rather removed from the group (2 standard deviations below mean group embeddedness).[7]

[7] This comes from weighting the expected variance from the equation by group embeddedness's value raised to its estimated coefficient: exp(-2.12)*embeddedness$_i$^-1.154.

Table 2. Heteroskedastic Regression of Linked Fate on Group Embeddedness and Individual Interests

	Black						Latino					
	2016		2020		2024		2016		2020		2024	
	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS
Group Embeddedness	0.623*	0.749*	0.623*	0.453*	0.679*	0.653*	0.814*	1.04*	0.679*	0.392*	0.591*	0.535*
	(0.092)	(0.060)	(0.064)	(0.042)	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.084)	(0.055)	(0.056)	(0.038)	(0.070)	(0.052)
Individual Interests	0.313*	0.069	0.119*	0.219*	0.064*	0.054*	-0.204	0.009	-0.079	0.121*	-0.166*	0.108*
	(0.119)	(0.041)	(0.050)	(0.031)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.115)	(0.042)	(0.068)	(0.033)	(0.075)	(0.049)
Interest in Politics	-0.057	-0.048	0.033	-0.095*	0.008	-0.002	-0.042	0.031	0.073	-0.007	0.052	0.109*
	(0.065)	(0.030)	(0.041)	(0.022)	(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.072)	(0.027)	(0.043)	(0.021)	(0.054)	(0.030)
Constant	0.402	0.098*	0.367*	0.161*	0.244*	0.191*	0.388*	-0.251*	0.158*	0.290*	0.263*	0.372*
	(0.002)	(0.040)	(0.057)	(0.025)	(0.021)	(0.019)	(0.086)	(0.075)	(0.063)	(0.035)	(0.075)	(0.055)
Variance Equation												
Group Embeddedness	-1.154*	-0.768*	-1.907*	0.715*	-1.254*	-0.372*	-0.629	0.724*	0.088	0.666*	-0.158	-0.372
	(0.522)	(0.220)	(0.367)	(0.180)	(0.378)	(0.134)	(0.539)	(0.218)	(0.278)	(0.172)	(0.342)	(0.279)
Individual Interests	-1.103	-0.397*	-0.891*	-0.530*	-1.202*	-0.512*	0.091	-0.128	0.177	-0.258*	-0.472	-0.674*
	(0.628)	(0.153)	(0.315)	(0.132)	(0.440)	(0.124)	(0.704)	(0.160)	(0.318)	(0.150)	(0.355)	(0.278)
Interest in Politics	0.714	0.102	0.298	-0.204*	0.314	-0.09	0.018	-0.208	-0.318	-0.250*	-0.014	0.107
	(0.397)	(0.108)	(0.245)	(0.095)	(0.267)	(0.072)	(0.397)	(0.107)	(0.208)	(0.093)	(0.247)	(0.144)
Constant	-2.12*	-1.282*	-1.545*	-2.292*	-2.063*	-2.044*	-2.437*	-2.338*	-2.485*	-2.483*	-2.247*	-2.209*
	(0.467)	(0.135)	(0.290)	(0.103)	(0.269)	(0.092)	(0.399)	(0.161)	(0.233)	(0.113)	(0.264)	(0.217)
N	217	2949	584	3923	385	4914	206	2384	595	3410	453	1053

Note: * $p < .05$. Maximum likelihood regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Demographic covariates included but withheld from table. CMPS years do not align with survey field dates. 2016 ran December 2016 through February 2017, 2020 ran April through August 2021, and 2024 iteration ran May to the beginning of September 2025.

However, support for this hypothesis is not entirely uniform. While we find support for the *agreement hypothesis* in three of the four remaining models, the estimated coefficient for the 2020 CMPS is statistically significant, but now positive. This is consistent with the *disagreement hypothesis*'s anticipation of increased variability in linked fate occurring among the more group embedded. While we acknowledge differences in sampling frame, the biggest difference between the 2020 ANES and 2020 CMPS is survey timing. The CMPS responses were collected after Joe Biden's election and during the start of Republican pushback against incorporating topics on diversity in public school curricula. The model result aligns with proposals that meso-level factors play a role in the construction of group meaning (Rogers and Kim 2023). During this time, embedded group members exhibited increased uncertainty in how best to address the group's position, even as they endorsed higher levels of linked fate than their less embedded coracials.

Turning to the results from Latinos, we find no clear support for the *agreement hypothesis* and instead find more evidence supporting the *disagreement hypothesis*. In 2016, estimates from the ANES indicate that Latinos who were more embedded in their group exhibited less variability in linked fate than those who are less embedded, but this result is quite imprecisely estimated. Estimates from that election's CMPS, in contrast, show that more group embedded Latinos were more varied in the linked fate they expressed compared to less group embedded Latinos. As the response equation shows, this is not because group embeddedness reduced linked fate. Across both data collections, and in fact for all tests among Latinos, group embeddedness reliably corresponds with heightened linked fate, even after controlling for key features of group heterogeneity in language of interview, generational status, and citizenship status. Turning to 2020, we find higher group embeddedness in both data collections corresponds with more variability in linked fate endorsement, but this is only significant in the CMPS sample. Things might have reversed in 2024, however, as embeddedness associated with less variability. Yet, in neither data collection is this reliably distinguishable from 0.

Overall, our results for Latinos offer no clear evidence for the *agreement hypothesis*, and more regular evidence for the *disagreement hypothesis*.[8] This aligns with longstanding questions about the political cohesiveness of Latinos, especially vis-à-vis Black Americans, given the group's greater heterogeneity (Abrajano and Alvarez 2010; Beltrán 2010; Fraga et al 2010; Hajnal and Lee 2011). Just because we can expect differences in linked fate that correspond to differences in group embeddedness, with more embeddedness aligning with more linked fate, we cannot assume that applies consistently across all respondents. Our interpretation of group embeddedness's effect is strengthened in our view by the estimates for individual interests in the variance equation. In all cases where we find significant results (7 of 12 models), the estimated coefficient for individual interests is negative, which is evidence that individual socio-economic status promotes more consistency in linked fate. We think this pattern informative as it suggests that as individual interests clarify, so too does the relevance of the group to the self.

Together, our tests emphasize the contingency of group meaning. Racial group embeddedness, while consistently promoting increased linked fate, does not necessarily contribute to unified endorsement of high linked fate. Among Black Americans, embeddedness in the group tends to decrease variability in endorsement in linked fate, which is consistent with the *agreement hypothesis*. Among Latino Americans, group immersion more often increases variability in linked fate endorsement than decreases it, consistent with the *disagreement hypothesis*. However, this evidence appears in only two tests, making this conclusion tentative, especially with the negative but imprecisely estimated results in other models. But critically, the variation relates to the concern with

[8] One might wonder if this follows from background factors like language of interview, generational status, and citizenship status confounding relationships by introducing heterogeneities in how Latinos understand linked fate. But the results are nearly identical when including these variables into the variance equation, indicating the patterns are unlikely due to a measure that is more error prone for this group.

context-specific fluctuation in group meaning. Importantly, that we find consistent evidence across different data collections points out our results are not driven by questionnaire content, sample selection, or other survey-design idiosyncrasies.

Assessing Scope with Individual Interests

People always negotiate group interests relative to their own. Improving the group's position may do little to improve one's own material or symbolic position. The higher status one is, as seen in things like occupation, income, and education, the better chances they have at individual mobility. While many see this mobility as providing an exit option for group members that undercuts group commitments (Dawson 1994; Ellemers et al 2002; Olson 1971; Tate 1993; Wilson 2011), it may instead increase the importance of group concerns as people have resources sufficient to meet basic needs (Enke et al 2022; Inglehart 2018). Having outside options makes it possible that individual interests condition the relevance of group embeddedness on group meaning.

To test this we re-estimate the models in Table 2 but include an interaction between embeddedness and individual interests into the variance equation. To facilitate interpretation, we report in Figure 1 the marginal effect of embeddedness across individual interests' range, reserving complete parameter estimates for the appendix (Table B1). We find limited evidence our individual interests constrain or enhance embeddedness's relevance and instead evidence that embeddedness and interests appear to independently contribute to variability in linked fate. We find significant moderation effects in 3 of 12 tests. Two of these involve Black Americans: the 2016 ANES and 2020 ANES. For Latinos, we find reliable moderation in the 2024 CMPS. Further, in all cases we find that stronger individual interests correspond with group embeddedness aligning with less response uncertainty, aligning with a post-material understanding of how people relate to social groups (Enke et al 2022). Taken together, conflict between group embeddedness and individual interests does little to explain inconsistency in linked fate endorsement. If anything, the present political environment sees the two go together to promote group meaning.

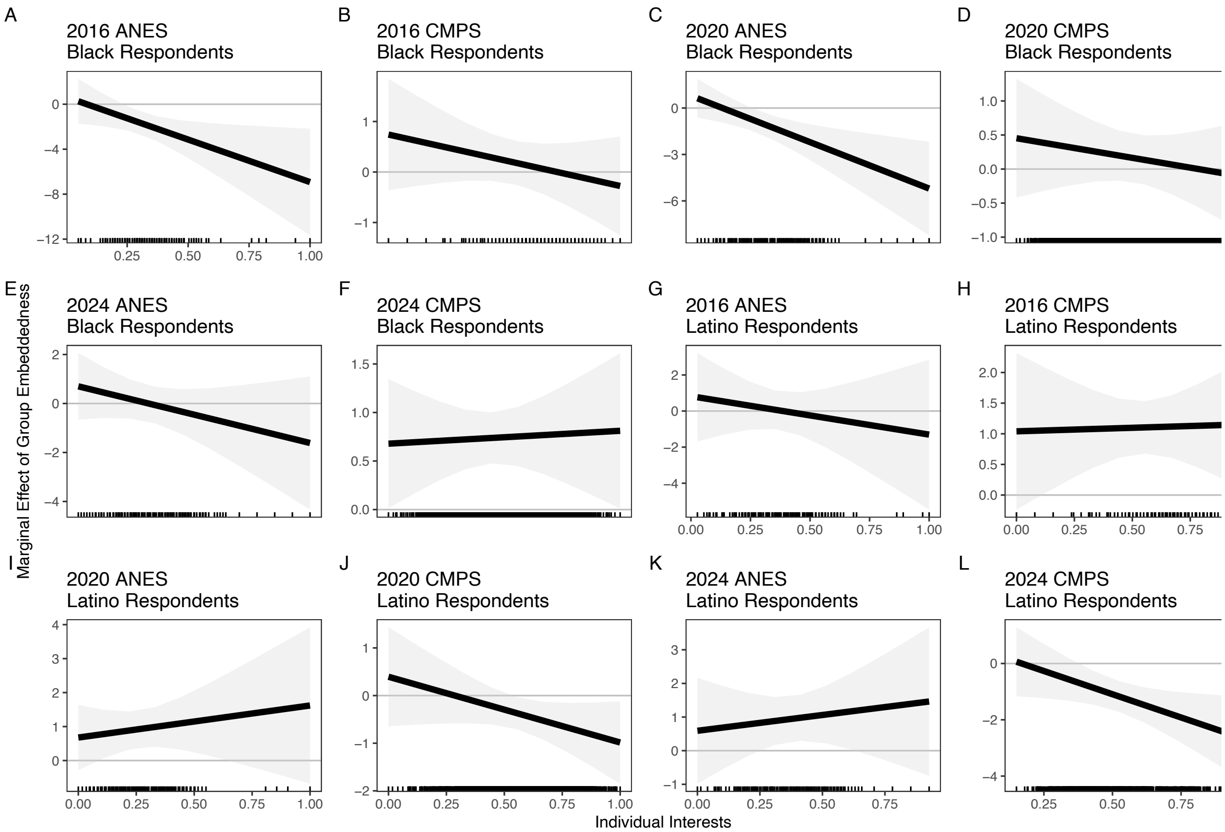

Figure 1. Moderating effect of individual interests on group embeddedness. Dashed lines show the distribution of individual interests. Shaded area visualizes 95% confidence intervals.

The Political Implications of Variability in Group Meaning

While group embeddedness is associated with higher average levels of linked fate, we have argued that it is variability in this endorsement of linked fate which is important for understanding political cohesion. To show behavioral manifestations of this variability we look at group cohesion in voting behavior and evaluations of public figures. We focus on the CMPS because its large sample sizes reduces variability attributable to sampling error, enabling sharper attention to these outcomes. We should see more similar vote preferences and figure evaluations in instances characterized by the *agreement hypothesis* and more variability in vote preferences and figure evaluations when groups are better characterized by the *disagreement hypothesis*.

We focus first on presidential vote choice, estimating, for each group in each year, a basic model. We predict support for the Democratic candidate over the Republican candidate as a function of linked fate after controlling for partisanship and background demographics: age, education, sex, income, and political interest. We view this setup not as an ideal vote choice model but instead as appropriate for considering linked fate's connection to candidate preference. We care less about explaining specific votes and instead use candidate support to demonstrate how uncertainty in an identity's meaning, seen here in linked fate, practically translates into volatility in voting behavior.

We use the vote choice model to run a series of simulations to predict the likelihood a sample typical individual supports the Democratic candidate. Across the simulations, we vary what this individual's level of linked fate is to see how candidate support varies.[9] We use the estimates from Table 2 to generate a distribution of possible linked fate values for someone at the sample average of group embeddedness, individual interests, and other demographic characteristics. The distribution's midpoint comes from the estimated response equation parameters reported in the top portion of Table 2. The distribution's standard deviation is defined by the estimated parameters of the variance equation. We then draw from this distribution a value of linked fate for this typical respondent and use it as the value of linked fate to predict candidate support using the vote choice model parameter estimates, repeating this process 5,000 times. To emphasize the importance of variability in content to variability in vote choice, we do not otherwise account for the precisions in the estimated coefficients. Our results focus only on consequences for understanding group

[9] In Appendix C, we additionally report simulations that examine linked fate's effect for people low, medium, and high on group embeddedness.

cohesion attributable to the uncertainty people have in what it means to be a part of their group, ignoring sampling variability.

Figure 2 reports the results of this analysis. The top panel focuses on variability in support for the Democratic candidate for Black respondents in 2016, 2020, and 2024, while the bottom panel repeats the same for Latino respondents. In 2016, we see that a typical Black respondent had a 0.92 probability of supporting Hillary Clinton over Donald Trump. But simply given uncertainty in linked fate's level due to group embeddedness, this support has a 90% confidence interval of 0.90 to 0.95. That is, setting aside sampling variability, variation in linked fate endorsement at typical group embeddedness levels seen in Table 2's variance panel introduces 5 points of uncertainty into our estimate of support for the Democratic candidate. This range widens markedly in 2020, evidence for variability in meaning underpinning less political cohesion. While the typical Black respondent had a 0.89 probability of supporting Joe Biden over Trump, this could have been as low has 0.85 or as high as 0.94. Likewise, in 2024, the typical Black respondent had a 0.75 probability of supporting Kamala Harris over Trump, with this effect ranging from 0.70 to 0.80 due simply to uncertainty in individuals' linked fate levels. Of course, these results still indicate that the typical Black respondent would be expected to overwhelmingly support the Democrat over the Republican. But again, the wide uncertainty in associations indicates less group cohesion compared to 2016. Existing research attends only to the shifting midpoints which reveal only average associations for a construct. Cohesion, instead, is better seen in the variability we recover by incorporating uncertainties in group meaning from the heteroskedastic regressions' variance equations.

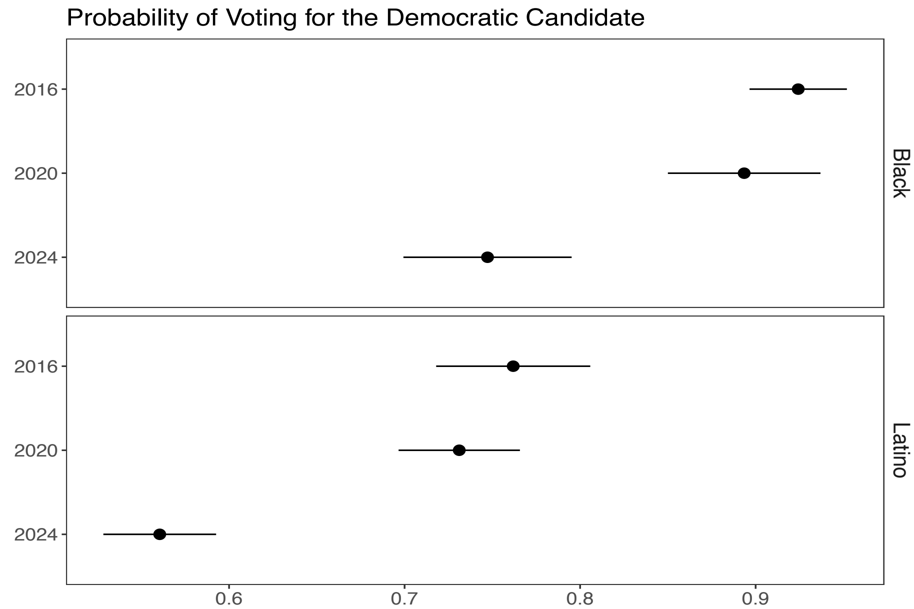

Figure 2. Average two-way support for the Democratic presidential candidate given variability in linked fate. Results from 5000 simulations of Trump favorability prediction for sample typical individual's varying linked fate endorsement. Simulation means and 90% intervals.

Figure 2's bottom panel shows how variability in linked fate works alongside short-term election-specific factors to mitigate Latinos' group cohesiveness politically. While a typical Latino in 2016 had a 0.76 probability of supporting the Democratic, this decreased to 0.73 in 2020 and 0.56 in 2024, consistent with interpretations of the declining relevance of group attachments to voting (Fraga, Velez, and West 2025). But more importantly, and again relevant to our claim about the consequences of contested group meaning, in each year we see substantial variability. This variability again is due not to sampling error but to uncertainty in how Latinos map group embeddedness to linked fate endorsement. In 2016, while Latinos overwhelmingly reported supporting Clinton relative to Trump, simply accounting for variability in linked fate attributable to differences in group embeddedness shows that this support could vary between 0.72 and 0.81. This 9-point range shrinks to 7-points in 2020 and 2024. A more complete story of shifting Latino voting behavior acknowledges not just the increased relevance of other attitudes (Fraga, Velez, and West 2025;

Geiger and Reny 2024), but also persistent uncertainty in how to engage politically on behalf of the group.

Repeating this same simulation approach for favorability towards Trump reinforces these takeaways. Figure 3 presents estimated favorability levels and their uncertainty for sample typical individuals, again ignoring sampling variability.[10] In 2016, the sample-typical Black respondent had an average favorability of Trump at 0.15, but this could be as low as 0.10 or as high as 0.20 just accounting for differences in how group embeddedness translates into linked fate endorsement. While 2020 sees similar average favorability, increased uncertainty in linked fate endorsement corresponds with estimates ranging from as low as 0.08 to as high as 0.21.[11] Even as group embeddedness continues to promote linked fate endorsement, and this corresponds with on average unfavorable views of Trump on average, the wider range indicates how variability in mapping group embeddedness to linked fate reduce cohesion in feelings about Trump among Black people in 2020. Turning to 2024, average feelings towards Trump are more positive compared to 2016 or 2020. The sample-typical Black respondent had an average 0.29 favorability of Trump that was also less variable than both 2016 and 2020: ranging from 0.25 to 0.33. Greater certainty in group meaning–seen through more similar linked fate endorsement across levels of group embeddedness–decreased differences in how Black folks felt about Trump in 2024.

Figure 3's bottom panel displays these effects for Latinos. In 2016, the sample-typical Latino respondent had a 0.23 average favorability of Trump. But we see similar amounts of variability in Latinos' feelings toward Trump as we did in Blacks'. A typical Latino's feelings could be as low as 0.19 or as high as 0.27 simply from heterogeneity in how people translate typical group

[10] Favorability is scaled 0-1. In Appendix C, we additionally report simulations that examine linked fate's effect for people low, medium, and high on group embeddedness.
[11] For reference, the "Slightly Unfavorable" response option is 0.33 and the "Strongly Unfavorable" response option is 0.

embeddedness levels into linked fate. In 2020, we see increased variability in Trump's favorability for an individual typical on group embeddedness. Mean Trump favorability was 0.28 for this respondent, but favorability could be as low as 0.22 or as high as 0.35. But as the estimate for 2024 shows, the shift from 2016 to 2020 reverted. In 2024, mean predicted favorability across simulations is 0.37 for a typical Latino respondent, with a narrow range (0.34–0.39). Recalling the results for Black people, Latino Americans' higher overall support for Trump in 2020 and 2024 is not clearly because of a weak sense of group interdependence. Instead, it represents a group negotiating what it means to be a group member. These results highlight how two people otherwise similar in group embeddedness can reach different, even conflicting, political opinions – their embeddedness leads them to different group meaning, here linked fate, with downstream effects for political opinions.

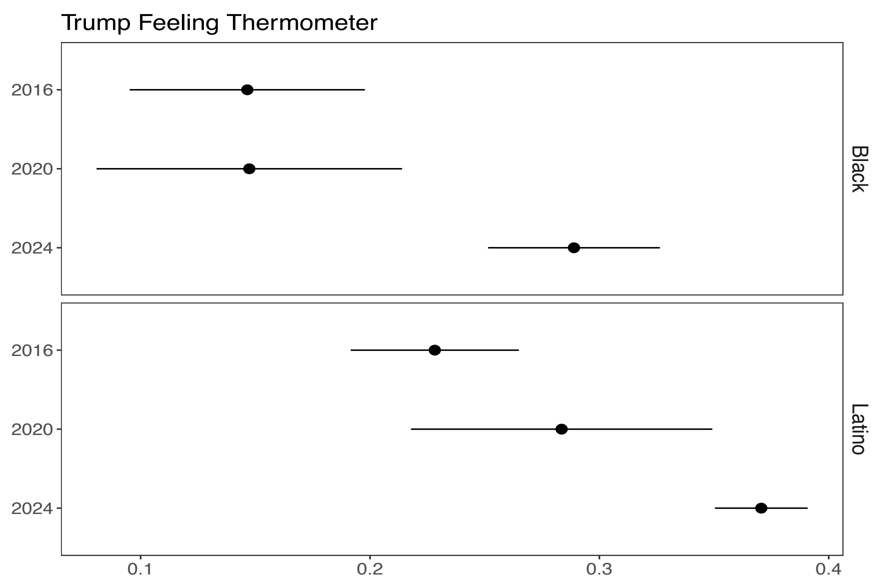

Figure 3. Average favorability towards Trump given variability in linked fate. Results from 5000 simulations of Trump favorability prediction for sample typical individual's varying linked fate endorsement. Simulation means and 90% intervals.

To reinforce this interpretation, we find important thinking about the changing average association between linked fate and our outcomes. While we can think about this as people shifting their votes or feelings about Trump to align with their linked fate, the typical explanation for such processes, it is also possible these shifting associations come from variation across elections in the distribution of linked fate (Engelhardt 2019), something the heteroskedastic regressions point to as likely. Allowing for a slight change in question wording between 2016 and 2020, we see less variability for both Blacks and Latinos in 2020. In 2024, we see similar variation among Blacks and again less among Latinos (Black: $SD_{2016} = 0.39$; $SD_{2020} = 0.31$; $SD_{2024} = 0.30$. Latino: $SD_{2016} = 0.40$; $SD_{2020} = 0.35$; $SD_{2024} = 0.30$).

Combined with the results from our tests of the *agreement* and *disagreement hypotheses*, we have improved understanding of substantive implications. Given the stable associations between linked fate and vote choice and Trump favorability between 2016 and 2020, seen in the overlapping estimates in Figures 2 and 3, the attenuated associations in 2024 are more likely from a decline the relevance of linked fate to Black opinion. The parameter estimates from Table 2 offer evidence for cohesive identity content and empirically we see no change in the distribution of members' sense of linked fate. But for Latinos, the shifting associations could be from shifts in overall linked fate endorsement or from shifts in how this outlook is linked to our outcomes, underscoring the greater fragility in group cohesion compared to Black Americans.

Conclusion

We proposed that a missing ingredient in accounts of Black and Latino voting behavior in recent elections can be seen in identity content. The more members of a group disagree about what it means to be a group member, the more varied the political consequences of group attachments. We theorized that we can better understand variation in identity content by thinking about how much group members at varying levels of embeddedness in their group agree on what it means to be a group member. Uniformity in group political decision-making then follows from understandings of identity content that are in part a product of how much group members immerse themselves psychologically, socially, and spatially in their group.

Analyses of several iterations of the ANES and CMPS point to differences across Black and Latino Americans in how consistently they connect exposure to group norms and values–what we called group embeddedness–to group meaning, which we measured with linked fate. While tests among Black Americans consistently supported our *agreement hypothesis*, with embeddedness decreasing variability in group meaning, tests among Latinos pointed more toward our *disagreement hypothesis*, with embeddedness promoting more variability in group meaning. We then showed how this variability has ramifications for group cohesion in other political opinions. Two otherwise similar individuals with the same degree of group embeddedness could have opinions that vary anywhere between 5 to 13 points. That results are generally consistent across both data sources strengthens our conclusions as less likely driven by idiosyncrasies of survey design or sample composition.

These results help us better understand the role of group attachments in political decision making. The evidence we have for the *agreement hypothesis* among Black Americans indicates that more group embedded individuals are more likely to agree on the implications of their group membership. Because people in the group agree on these implications, we can better explain changes over time in some facet of attachment like linked fate's association with political judgments. Based on Figures 2 and 3, shifts across elections for Black Americans are more likely due to changes in the relevance of this sense of group interdependence to politics given consistent agreement. In contrast, because we find more evidence for the *disagreement hypothesis* for Latinos we have a different set of explanations available. Uncertainty in the political implications of group interdependence opens the door for reliance on other orientations or contradictory political actions taken on behalf of the group. Group attachments do not need to diminish in their importance; instead, variability in how people think about their group attenuates the connection these attachments have to political outcomes, such as Democratic vote choice.

We have focused on linked fate as our measure of group meaning because it captures a sense of interdependence and interconnectedness. While useful, this perspective can miss some of the critical political implications of interdependence that we suggested relate to heterogeneity in interpretations of group meaning (Junn 2006; Lee 2008). Indeed, Stephens-Dougan and colleagues (2026) offer evidence that it is important consider specifically the politics in group cohesion. Consequently, we replicated our analyses where possible substituting linked fate along with a measure of racial grievance: concerns with discrimination and belief in its structural origins (Stephens-Dougan et al 2026). These results, reported in Appendix E, offer insights that complement and extend those here. We find continued support for the *agreement hypothesis* among Black Americans. For Latinos, we find evidence for both the *agreement* and *disagreement* hypotheses. While these latter results diverge from our more consistent evidence of disagreement using linked fate alone, the fluctuation across elections points to similar contextual contingencies, a point complemented by these differences across operationalizations.

These results also have implications for the linked fate operationalization (e.g., Gay, Hochschild, and White 2016). They point to potential issues in comparing what affirmative responses to statements that what happens to others in one's racial group will happen to them across groups with different experiences and histories. These group-based differences also speak to the measure not clearly indexing a sense of group position and reasons for this but more plausibly a more general sense of shared experiences unrelated to specific causes or consequences for these (Gay, Hochschild, and White 2016; Stephens-Dougan et al 2026).

We have focused on Black and Latino Americans as a way to link identity content to group cohesion in very specific cases. But the implications are general. A natural extension would be to Asian Americans to see how other marginalized racial groups navigate members' varied claims on the panethnic label. It would be particularly interesting to contrast assessments of South with East

Asian individuals given the latter's prototypicality for the category (Kim 2023). Or one could bring studies of category meaning to whites to see how much the recent "white identity politics" is consensually held (Jardina 2019). Then natural extensions could be to other groups like sexual minorities or feminists that work to advance the interests of marginalized individuals, or even members of different religious groups. All allow for different ways identities can be contested, with implications for these groups' political cohesion.

Moving from our specific case, the results point to the need for scholars to attend to the content of group attachments. How members of a group appraise its meaning is not always uniform or stable across elections. At times, there are multiple, conflicting interpretations of how to politically advance the group's position, or whether politics is even relevant. Exploring variation in identity content provides new avenues of research for scholars interested in the link between identities and politics, something particularly consequential if identities are the "very basis of reasons" animating many individuals' political decisions (Achen and Bartels 2016).

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Appendix

Appendix A. Study Question Wording and Dimension Estimation

Table A1. Survey Question Wording

<table>
<tr><td></td><td></td><td colspan="3">ANES</td><td colspan="3">CMPS</td></tr>
<tr><td></td><td></td><td>2016</td><td>2020</td><td>2024</td><td>2016</td><td>2020</td><td>2024</td></tr>
<tr><td>Group Embeddedness</td><td>Perceived Discrimination</td><td colspan="3">How much discrimination is there in the United States today against each of the following groups? [in-group]
5 (A great deal) - 1 (None at all)</td><td colspan="2">How much discrimination is there in the United States today against each of the following groups? [in-group] 4 (A lot) - 1 (None at all)</td><td>How much discrimination is there in the United States today against each of the following groups? [in-group] 5 (A lot) - 1 (None at all)</td></tr>
<tr><td></td><td>Discrimination Experiences</td><td colspan="3">How much discrimination have YOU personally faced because of your ethnicity or race?
5 (A great deal) - 1 (None at all)</td><td>Have you ever been treated unfairly or personally experienced discrimination because of your race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, being an immigrant, religious heritage or having an accent?
Yes, No
IF YES, "In your opinion, were you unfairly treated because of your...racial background or ethnicity"</td><td>In the past four years, have you experienced discrimination or exclusion because you are [race] in any of the following settings? [Sum of:]
When seeking medical care for you or your family
In dealings with police
In dealings with immigration officers
At your place of work
In a restaurant, theater, or other place of entertainment
In a store
From other people
Other</td><td>Have you ever been treated unfairly or personally experienced discrimination because of your race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality,
being an immigrant, religious heritage or having an accent?
Yes, No
IF YES, "In your opinion, were you unfairly treated because of your...racial background or ethnicity"</td></tr>
<tr><td></td><td>Racial Identity</td><td colspan="3">How important is being [race] to your identity?
1 (Not at all important) - 5 (Extremely important)</td><td>Some people feel positively about the link they have with their racial or ethnic group members, while others feel negatively about the idea that their lives may be influenced by how well the larger group is doing.
Which comes closer to your feelings?
(3) I feel positively about this link with my racial or ethnic group
(1) I feel negatively about this link with my racial or ethnic group
(2) Neither positive or negative</td><td>How important is being [race] to your identity?
1 (Not at all important) - 5 (Extremely important)</td><td>How much is being [race] an important part of how you see yourself?
1 (Not at all important) – 4 (Very important)</td></tr>
<tr><td></td><td>Group Political Influence/Power</td><td colspan="3">Would you say that [ingroup] have too much influence in American politics,
just about the right amount of influence in American politics, or too little
influence in American politics? 1 (too much) - 3 (too little)</td><td></td><td colspan="2">How much can [RACIAL GROUP] like you influence the outcome of elections? 1 (Not at all) – 5 (A great deal)</td></tr>
</table>

	Political Interest	How often do you pay attention to what's going on in government and politics? 1 (never) - 5 (always)	Some people are very interested in politics while other people can't stand politics, how about you? Are you... 1 (Not at all interested in politics) – 4 (Very interested)		Thinking back to last year, how often did you follow news and information about the 2024 presidential election? 1 (Never or avoided it) – 5 (Every single day)
	Religiosity	Lots of things come up that keep people from attending religious services even if they want to. Thinking about your life these days, do you ever attend religious services, apart from occasional weddings, baptisms or funerals? 0 (No), Yes If Yes: Do you go to religious services every week, almost every week, once or twice a month, a few times a year, or never? 0 (never) - 5 (every week)	Do you attend religious service or gathering: at least every week, almost every week, a few times a month, only a few times during the year, hardly ever or never? 6 (At least every week) – 1 (Never) [Religious nones included at 0 but were not asked this question]	Thinking back to before the coronavirus pandemic, generally speaking, about how often did you used to participate in worship services or religious rituals with others? 6 (More than once per week) – 1 (Never)	Generally speaking, about how often do you participate in worship services or religious rituals with others? 6 (More than once per week) – 1 (Never)
	Relative Economic Status (Black)		On the whole compared to white Americans, would you say that the economic position of black Americans is… 1 (Much Better) – 5 (Much worse)		
	Indigenous Media Exposure		When it comes to news and current affairs? Would you say you watch TV or online news.. 1 (Mostly mainstream) – 5 (Mostly Black oriented) [Black] 1 (Mostly English-language) – 5 (Mostly Spanish-language) [Latino]		
	Group Economic Gains			How much real improvement do you think there has been in the economic position of [race] in the past few years? Now what about in your neighborhood. How much real improvement do you think there has been in the economic position of [ingroup] in your neighborhood the past few years 1 (Not much at all) - 3 (a lot) [average of these two items]	
	Proportion Coracial (Zip)			2020 5 year ACS	2023 5 year ACS
Individual Interests	Education		What is the highest level of education you completed? 1 (Grades 1-8) – 6 (Post-graduate education)		

	Income		What was your total combined household income in 2015 before taxes. This question is completely confidential and just used to help classify the responses, but it is very important to the research. 1 (Less than 20K) – 12 (200k+)		
	Income -- Refused		What was your total combined household income in 2015 before taxes. This question is completely confidential and just used to help classify the responses, but it is very important to the research. 0 (answered) 1 (Did not answer)		
	Logged Income Per Capita (Zip)			2020 5 year ACS	2023 5 year ACS
Demographics	Sex	What is your gender? 1 = female, 0 = male	Gender 1 = Female 0 = Male		
	Age	Age in years			
	Generational status (Latinos)	First = born outside of the US or Puerto Rico; Second = born in US or Puerto Rico but parents born in another country; Third+ = born in US or Puerto Rico and at least one parent born in US or Puerto Rico			
	Mexican Ancestry (Latinos)	Administrative summary variable	Hispanics and Latinos have their roots in many different countries in Latin America. To what country do you or your family trace your ancestry?...Mexico		
	Citizenship Status (Latinos)		1 = Born in US or Permanent resident (naturalized, visa etc)		
	English Interview (Latinos)		Record language of survey: 1 = English 0 = otherwise		
Group Grievances	Linked Fate	How much do you think that what happens generally to [ingroup] people in this country will affect what happens in your life? 1 (Not at all) - 4 (A lot)	Do you think what happens generally to [ingroup] people in this country will have something to do with what happens in your life? Yes, No (1) If YES: Will it affect you: 4 (A lot) - 2 (Not very much)	How much do you think what happens to the following groups here in the U.S. will have something to do with what happens in YOUR life? … What happens to [ingroup] people will have 1 (Nothing to do with what happens in my life) – 5 (A huge amount to do with what happens in my life)	
	Perceived Discrimination		How much discrimination is there in the United States today against each of the following groups? [in-group] 1 (A lot) - 4 (None at all)		
	Group Political Influence/Power				

	Structural Racism Attributions (Latino)			How would you define racism in this country? 1 (As acts of discrimination that individuals commit against individuals of another racial group) - 3 (As acts of discrimination that our country's institutions and systems commit against individuals)	
	Structural Racism Attributions (Black)	Generations of slavery and discrimination have created conditions that make it difficult for Blacks to work their way out of the lower class. 1 (strongly disagree) – 5 (strongly agree) It's really a matter of some people not trying hard enough; if Blacks would only try harder they could be just as well off as Whites. 5 (strongly disagree) – 1 (strongly agree)		How would you define racism in this country? 1 (As acts of discrimination that individuals commit against individuals of another racial group) - 3 (As acts of discrimination that our country's institutions and systems commit against individuals) Generations of slavery and discrimination have created conditions that make it difficult for Blacks to work their way out of the lower class. 1 (strongly disagree) – 5 (strongly agree) It's really a matter of some people not trying hard enough; if Blacks would only try harder they could be just as well off as Whites. 5 (strongly disagree) – 1 (strongly agree)	Generations of slavery and discrimination have created conditions that make it difficult for Blacks to work their way out of the lower class. 1 (strongly disagree) – 5 (strongly agree) It's really a matter of some people not trying hard enough; if Blacks would only try harder they could be just as well off as Whites. 5 (strongly disagree) – 1 (strongly agree)
	Ingroup has political say		How often would you say [ingroup] have a say in how government handles important issues? 1 (Never) - 5 (All the time)		
	Racism is a problem		Some people say that the nomination of Barack Obama for president of the United States suggests that racism no longer exists in American society and politics. Would you say that… 1 (Racism once exists but no longer exists in our society) - 3 (Racism remains a major problem in our society)		
	Achieved Racial Equality		Do you think [ingroup]: 1 (Have achieved racial equality) - 4 (Will never achieve racial equality)		
	Relative Economic Status (Black)		On the whole compared to white Americans, would you say that the economic position of black Americans is… 1 (Much Better) – 5 (Much worse)		
	Racial Problems Prevalent			Racial problems in the U.S. are rare, isolated situations 1 (Strongly disagree) -- 5 (strongly agree)	
	Angry about racism			I am angry that racism exists 1 (Strongly disagree) -- 5 (strongly agree)	
Group Embeddedness	Discrimination Experiences	How much discrimination have YOU personally faced because of your ethnicity or	Have you ever been treated unfairly or personally experienced	In the past four years, have you experienced discrimination or exclusion because you are	Have you ever been treated unfairly or personally experienced discrimination

(Grievances Models)		race? 5 (A great deal) - 1 (None at all)	discrimination because of your race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, being an immigrant, religious heritage or having an accent? Yes, No IF YES, "In your opinion, were you unfairly treated because of your...racial background or ethnicity"	[race] in any of the following settings? [Sum of:] When seeking medical care for you or your family In dealings with police In dealings with immigration officers At your place of work In a restaurant, theater, or other place of entertainment In a store From other people Other	because of your race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, being an immigrant, religious heritage or having an accent? Yes, No IF YES, "In your opinion, were you unfairly treated because of your...racial background or ethnicity"
	Racial Identity	How important is being [race] to your identity? 1 (Not at all important) - 5 (Extremely important)	Some people feel positively about the link they have with their racial or ethnic group members, while others feel negatively about the idea that their lives may be influenced by how well the larger group is doing. Which comes closer to your feelings? (3) I feel positively about this link with my racial or ethnic group (1) I feel negatively about this link with my racial or ethnic group (2) Neither positive or negative	How important is being [race] to your identity? 1 (Not at all important) - 5 (Extremely important)	How much is being [race] an important part of how you see yourself? 1 (Not at all important) – 4 (Very important)
	Political Interest	How often do you pay attention to what's going on in government and politics? 1 (never) - 5 (always)	Some people are very interested in politics while other people can't stand politics, how about you? Are you... 1 (Not at all interested in politics) – 4 (Very interested)		Thinking back to last year, how often did you follow news and information about the 2024 presidential election? 1 (Never or avoided it) – 5 (Every single day)
	Indigenous Media Exposure		When it comes to news and current affairs? Would you say you watch TV or online news.. 1 (Mostly mainstream) – 5 (Mostly Black oriented) [Black] 1 (Mostly English-language) – 5 (Mostly Spanish-language) [Latino]		
	Religiosity	Lots of things come up that keep people from attending religious services even if they want to. Thinking about your life these days, do you ever attend religious services, apart from occasional weddings, baptisms or funerals? 0 (No), Yes If Yes: Do you go to religious services every week, almost every week, once or twice a month, a few times a year, or never? 0 (never) - 5 (every week)			
	Proportion Coracial (Zip)			2020 5 year ACS	2023 5 year ACS

Table A2 reports the estimated component loadings from the PCA models used to create our measures of group embeddedness and individual interests. Our aim in using this approach is to flexibly incorporate several pieces of information related to these constructs into a single dimension. We take no position on what the true underlying dimensional of each concept is but instead focus on a single dimension to capture the intersection of the several indicators.

Our interest in the specific predictors follows from item availability and conceptual fit with facets of group embeddedness identified in prior work (Anoll, Davenport, and Lienesch 2025; Strawbridge 2025). We think about these as a mix of group place and space (*geography*), social context (*social*), and personal allegiances (*psychology*).

Data availability limit our ability to include information on all facets across surveys. The CMPS offers easier geographic indicators than the ANES, facilitating including measures of coracial presence in one's zip code as our *geographic* indicator.

Social indicators reflect exposure to co-racials in close settings and integration into information structures. Following prior studies of these meso-level factors (e.g., Dawson 1994; Harris-Lacewell 2006), our social indicators include religiosity, political interest, and indigenous media exposure. While others have operationalized social context with egocentric network generators (Anoll et al 2025), similar metrics are largely unavailable in our data collections. But generally, we think about the social context as broader than concrete personal relations. Social can include distal aspects, with parasocial contact matter as much, if not more, than the personal contact emphasized (Anoll et al 2025).

Psychological indicators reflect subjective understandings about the group's experiences and how the individual's own experiences relate to these. Items reflect these ideas include measures of perceived discrimination, personal experiences of discrimination on the basis of race, beliefs about the group's social and political influence, its relative economic status or absolute economic gains, and racial identity centrality or affect. While some might argue explaining linked fate as a function of identity-related measures is tautological, we see this only because of some scholars' use of linked fate as a measure of group attachment. We see it as an outgrowth of this, as Pérez and Cobian (2024) summarize "linked fate is a byproduct of inter- and intragroup processes" (see also Leach et al 2008).

We note that while the parameter estimates for the individual interests indicators remain largely similar across data collections, we do see variation for the embeddedness indicators. This is in part a function of using different items to capture the same concept. It can also reflect how a specific indicator of embeddedness changes its association with others over time. We have no position on which specific metrics – social, psychological, or geographic – ought to be more or less likely to expose people to group norms, interests, and prototypes, so we take this variation as interesting but not consequential for our theory testing. Our argument hinges simply on the intersection of several related but distinct facets (see also Wuttke et al 2020).

Informatively, even though we see variation in the relevance of individual items to the underlying embeddedness dimension, this appears unrelated to the substantive implications embeddedness has. Table 1 showed that embeddedness consistently positively predicts endorsement of linked fate. Similarly, the near uniform negative estimate for embeddedness in the variance equations for Black Americans supports the idea of limited substantive consequences. That the estimates for embeddedness among Latinos in the 2016 ANES and CMPS each come from strong connections to discrimination and group attachments points to the reversed parameter estimate for embeddedness in the variance equations as less likely due to the specific operationalization within each study.

Table A2: PCA Loadings for Group Embeddedness and Individual Interests Constructs

	Black						Latino					
	2016		2020		2024		2016		2020		2024	
	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS
Group Embeddedness												
Perceived Discrimination	0.759	0.343	0.607	0.307	0.819	0.714	0.798	0.634	0.799	0.249	0.749	0.702
Experienced Discrimination	0.695	0.501	0.603	0.21	0.579	0.533	0.513	0.573	0.682	0.345	0.648	0.615
Group Attachments	0.462	0.464	0.734	0.618	0.604	0.66	0.719	0.678	0.664	0.56	0.671	0.624
Views on group political Influence	0.538		0.569	0.681	0.605		0.506		0.51	0.71	0.597	
Political Interest	0.153	0.624	0.369	0.645	0.338	0.541	-0.002	0.36	-0.028	0.477	0.131	0.351
Religiosity	-0.268	0.357	0.218	0.394	0.091	0.268	0.087	0.273	-0.058	0.376	-0.077	0.231
Zip share coracial				0.125		0.075				0.137		-0.079
Consume In-group media		0.296						0.42				
Don't consume media		-0.631						-0.345				
Whites doing better economically than Blacks		0.106										
Group economic status improving				0.237						0.452		
Individual Interests												
Education	0.666	0.731	0.593	0.693	0.665	0.813	0.584	0.726	0.399	0.713	0.599	0.78
Income	0.862	0.847	0.882	0.85	0.87	0.808	0.871	0.857	0.867	0.833	0.865	0.81
Income: Refused/Don't Know	0.612	-0.497	0.651	-0.475	0.579	-0.118	0.647	-0.534	0.698	-0.476	0.574	-0.137
Zip per capita income (logged)				0.415		0.499				0.518		0.632

Note: Row labels paraphrase item content. Complete question wording available in Table A1

Appendix B. Individual Interests' Conditioning Effect

Table B1 reports the parameter estimates for the models testing the conditioning effect of individual interest on group embeddedness in the variance equation.

Table B1. Heteroskedastic Regression of Linked Fate on Group Embeddedness and Individual Interests, and their Interaction

	Black						Latino					
	2016		2020		2024		2016		2020		2024	
	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS
	0.639*	0.741*	0.630*	0.453*	0.700*	0.679*	0.822*	1.040*	0.677*	0.395*	0.592*	0.558*
Group Embeddedness	(0.091)	(0.060)	(0.063)	(0.042)	(0.079)	(0.027)	(0.085)	(0.055)	(0.056)	(0.038)	(0.070)	(0.053)
	0.250*	0.069	0.110*	0.219*	0.113	0.064*	-0.186	0.009	-0.08	0.123*	-0.163*	0.096
Individual Interests	(0.126)	(0.041)	(0.048)	(0.031)	(0.069)	(0.024)	(0.116)	(0.042)	(0.068)	(0.032)	(0.074)	(0.050)
Interest in Politics	-0.051	-0.047	0.031	-0.095*	-0.036	0.008	-0.039	0.031	0.075	-0.007	0.049	0.106*
	(0.063)	(0.030)	(0.040)	(0.022)	(0.053)	(0.015)	(0.072)	(0.027)	(0.043)	(0.020)	(0.054)	(0.030)
Constant	0.398*	0.104*	0.371*	0.161*	0.289*	0.244*	0.383*	-0.251*	0.158*	0.287*	0.264*	0.364*
	(0.086)	(0.040)	(0.055)	(0.025)	(0.073)	(0.021)	(0.085)	(0.075)	(0.063)	(0.035)	(0.075)	(0.054)
Variance Equation												
	1.176	-0.22	-0.325	1.008*	-0.542	-0.431	0.162	0.661	-0.168	1.429*	-0.508	1.33
Group Embeddedness	(1.164)	(0.562)	(0.638)	(0.445)	(0.693)	(0.339)	(1.330)	(0.652)	(0.490)	(0.530)	(0.803)	(0.838)
	3.424	0.302	3.149*	-0.2	0.241	-0.603	1.232	-0.203	-0.409	0.408	-0.973	1.426
Individual Interests	(2.195)	(0.680)	(1.464)	(0.477)	(1.274)	(0.494)	(1.900)	(0.756)	(1.008)	(0.464)	(1.093)	(1.025)
Embeddedness*	-7.562*	-1.018	-5.832*	-0.577	-2.313	0.133	-2.129	0.115	0.944	-1.381	0.939	-3.301*
Interests	(3.410)	(0.965)	(2.021)	(0.801)	(1.915)	(0.697)	(3.264)	(1.130)	(1.546)	(0.908)	(1.943)	(1.537)
	0.797	0.102	0.243	-0.208*	0.335	-0.086	-0.024	-0.207	-0.321	-0.256*	-0.018	0.095
Interest in Politics	(0.408)	(0.108)	(0.246)	(0.095)	(0.268)	(0.072)	(0.404)	(0.106)	(0.208)	(0.093)	(0.247)	(0.145)
Constant	-3.553*	-1.651*	-2.605*	-2.454*	-2.130*	-2.023*	-2.836*	-2.297*	-2.331*	-2.847*	-1.986*	-3.279*
	(0.784)	(0.372)	(0.447)	(0.248)	(0.445)	(0.229)	(0.729)	(0.432)	(0.347)	(0.263)	(0.476)	(0.541)
N	217	2949	584	3923	385	4914	206	2384	595	3410	453	1053

Note: * $p < .05$. Maximum likelihood regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Demographic covariates included but withheld from table. CMPS years do not align with survey field dates. 2016 ran December 2016 through February 2017, 2020 ran April through August 2021, and 2024 iteration ran May to the beginning of September 2025.

Appendix C. Political Cohesion and Variation in Identity Content

Figures C1 and C2 show variability in vote choice and Trump favorability for individuals low, average, and high in group embeddedness. Low and high are determined empirically as individuals scoring 1 standard deviation below or above the same average, respectively.

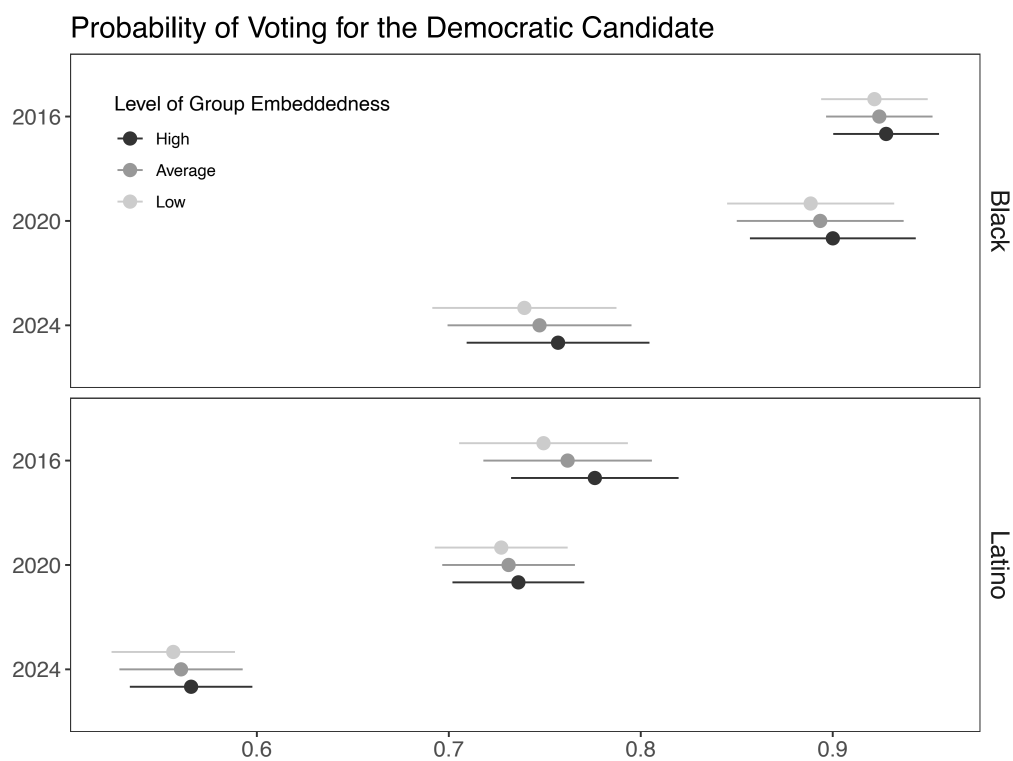

Figure C1: Linked fate's variable influence on two-way support for the Democratic presidential candidate across levels of group embeddedness. Results from 5000 simulations of vote choice prediction based on variability in linked fate.

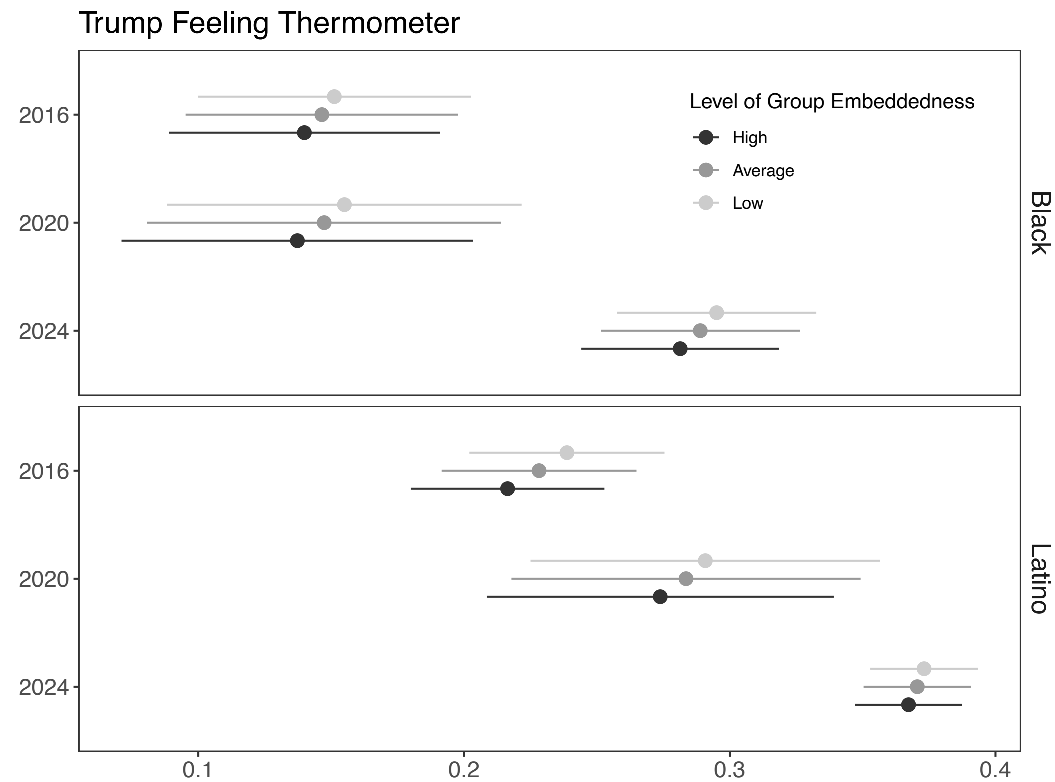

Figure C2: Linked fate's variable influence on favorability towards Trump across levels of group embeddedness. Results from 5000 simulations of Trump favorability prediction based on variability in linked fate.

As an additional analysis of how this uncertainty in linked fate's effect affects understandings of group cohesion, we consider linked fate's relationship with a desire for a coracial candidate. Descriptive representation is a key avenue for racially marginalized groups to achieve stronger representation (Bobo & Gilliam 1990; Gay 2002) and thus important to understand how group interconnectedness can variably impact support for coracial representation. We again run simulations where we predict the likelihood a sample typical individual's support for a coracial candidate given the variation in linked fate.

Between the survey years, the questions we can use to assess this varied. In 2016, the support for a coracial candidate comes from questions that asked respondents how much the following candidates would represent their interests where candidates varied based on race and gender. We took the difference between feeling of representation between coracial and White candidates of the same gender for Black and Latino respondents. We then averaged the difference for men and women candidates to capture a general favorability to coracial representation regardless of gender. In 2020, respondents were asked how important a candidate's racial background is to their vote choice. In 2024, respondents were asked how important it is that more coracial politicians are elected. Because these measures differ, we refrain from making cross-year comparisons because to do so would require strong assumptions about how the questions (equivalently) capture latent support for descriptive representation. As such, we only make comparisons within survey years across racial groups.

Figure C3 shows that in 2016, a sample typical Black respondent had an average of 0.64, with a 90% confidence interval from 0.60 to 0.68. Meanwhile, a sample typical Latino respondent had an average of 0.60, with a slightly narrower interval from 0.57 to 0.62. These results indicate that Black respondents had a slightly higher support for coracial representation, but linked fate has more diffuse effects for Black respondents than Latino respondents.

In 2020, a sample typical Black respondent had a mean response of 0.49, slightly below 0.5 which is the "neither important/unimportant". Yet, this support's 90% interval ranges from 0.46 to 0.53. Linked fate again had slightly lower positive effects on support for coracial representation among Latinos, but a narrower interval. A sample typical Latino respondent had a mean response of 0.42. However, this support's 90% interval only ranges from 0.39 to 0.44. Similar to 2016, linked fate led to a higher support for coracial representation among Black people, but its effect was more diffuse than for Latino people.

In contrast, in 2024, Black and Latino people had equivalent effects of linked fate. A typical Black respondent had a mean response of 0.75, which corresponds to the "somewhat important" category. The effect varied widely from as low as 0.65 to as high as 0.86. Similarly, a typical Black respondent had a mean response of 0.74 and the effect of linked fate varied widely from 0.60 to 0.89. This shift to having parallel effects and a wide range of uncertainty may represent a shift from past years given the identity context of 2024. However, given different question wordings, it may be a shift in how the different questions capture support for coracial descriptive representation.

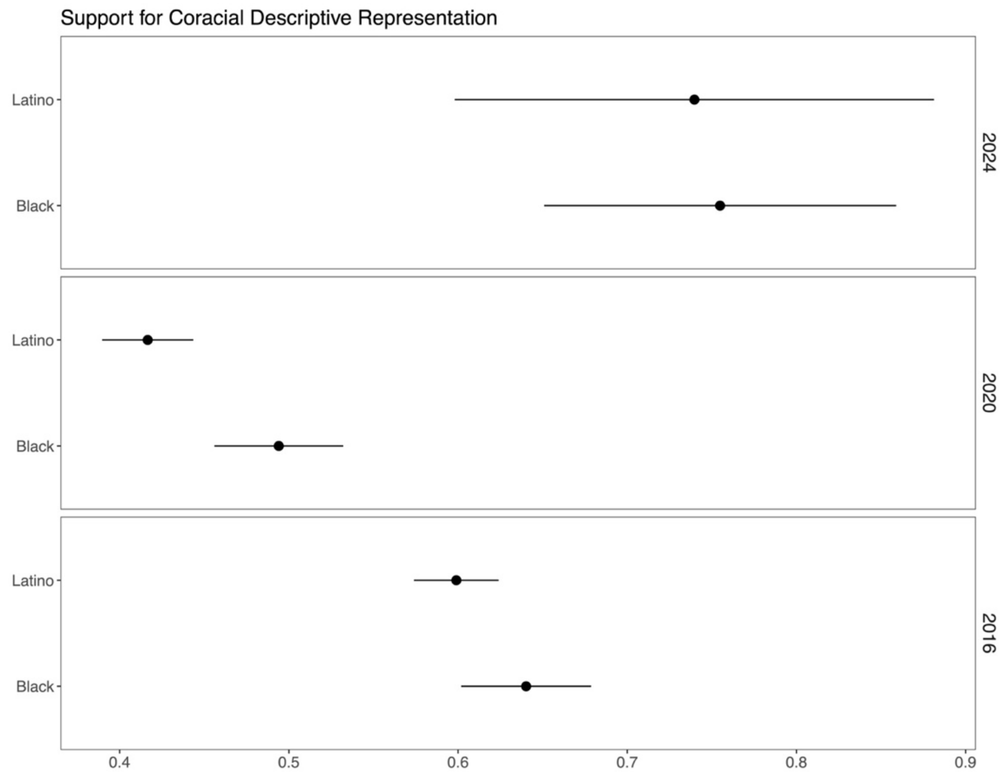

Figure C3. Linked fate's variable influence on importance of co-racial candidate. Results from 5000 simulations of support for racial descriptive representation prediction based on variability in linked fate.

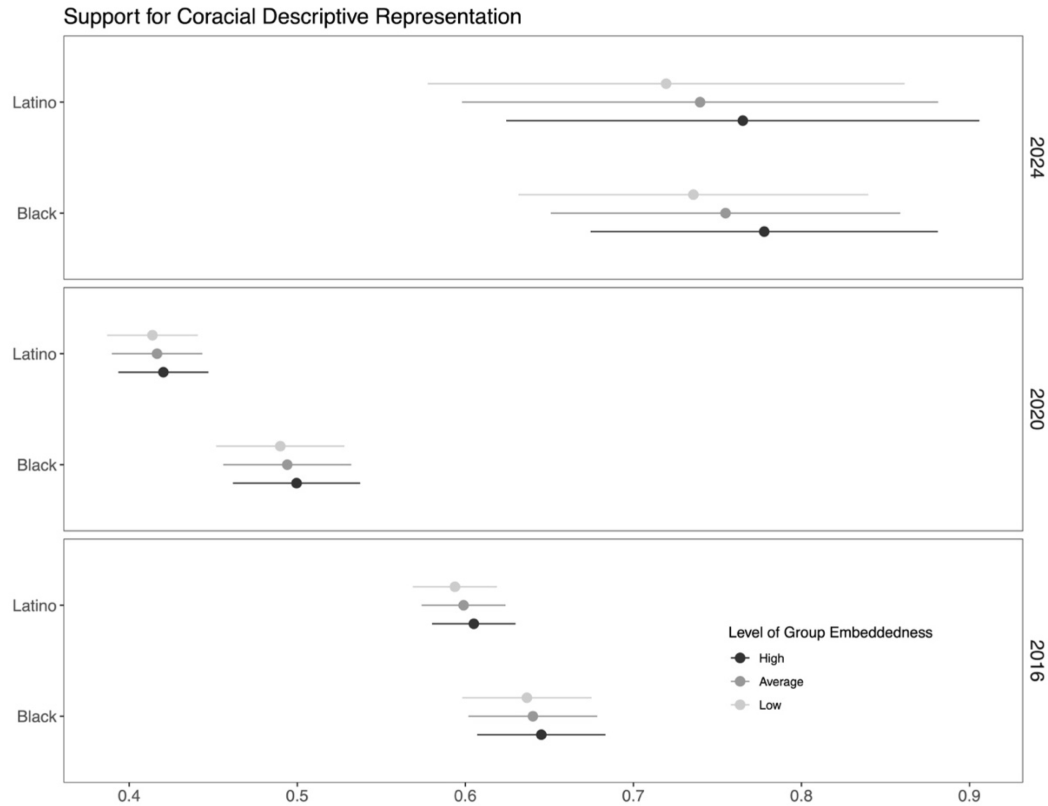

Figure C4. Linked fate's variable influence on importance of co-racial candidate across levels of group embeddedness. Results from 5000 simulations of support for racial descriptive representation prediction based on variability in linked fate.

Appendix D. Parameter Estimates for Simulation Models

Tables D1-D2 report the parameter estimates for the models serving as the choice models used in the simulations exploring observable patterns consistent with our argument that variability in linked fate endorsement aligns with variation in political cohesion.

Table D1: Parameter Estimates for Simulation Models Predicting Vote Choice

	Dependent variable: Vote Choice					
	Black			Latino		
	2016	2020	2024	2016	2020	2024
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Linked Fate	0.030*	0.092***	0.084***	0.093***	0.084***	0.067**
	(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.022)
Partisanship	-0.408***	-0.609***	-0.814***	-0.670***	-0.864***	-0.944***
	(0.019)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.021)	(0.016)	(0.016)
Women	0.027**	0.025**	0.080***	0.017	0.010	0.056***
	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.010)	(0.013)	(0.011)	(0.013)
Age	-0.008	-0.010	0.167***	0.069*	-0.046	0.044
	(0.022)	(0.019)	(0.025)	(0.032)	(0.025)	(0.034)
Education	0.036	0.073***	0.011	-0.099***	0.025	-0.018
	(0.023)	(0.019)	(0.024)	(0.028)	(0.023)	(0.027)
Income	0.003	-0.009	-0.020	0.021	-0.015	0.022
	(0.019)	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.028)	(0.020)	(0.023)
Income- Don't Know	-0.032	0.008	0.123	0.030	0.018	0.007
	(0.020)	(0.016)	(0.091)	(0.023)	(0.019)	(0.093)
Political Interest	-0.066***	-0.089***		-0.092***	-0.095***	
	(0.017)	(0.014)		(0.024)	(0.018)	
Campaign Interest			-0.043*			-0.004
			(0.017)			(0.022)
Constant	0.995***	0.974***	0.859***	1.043***	1.051***	0.889***
	(0.018)	(0.015)	(0.021)	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.027)
Observations	2,588	3,988	3,859	2,373	3,894	2,816
Note:				*p<0.05; **p<0.01, ***p<0.001		

Table D2: Parameter Estimates for Simulation Models Predicting Trump Favorability

	Dependent variable: Trump Favorability					
	Black			Latino		
	2016	2020	2024	2016	2020	2024
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Linked Fate	-0.055***	-0.141***	-0.057***	-0.078***	-0.159***	-0.046**
	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.016)	(0.017)
Partisanship	0.327***	0.434***	0.421***	0.454***	0.617***	0.598***
	(0.021)	(0.016)	(0.015)	(0.018)	(0.015)	(0.014)
Women	-0.061***	-0.048***	-0.098***	-0.037***	-0.033***	-0.072***
	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.009)	(0.011)	(0.010)	(0.010)
Age	-0.014	-0.128***	-0.187***	-0.029	-0.047*	-0.050
	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.023)	(0.026)	(0.023)	(0.027)
Education	-0.141***	-0.039*	-0.018	-0.011	-0.044*	0.073***
	(0.025)	(0.019)	(0.022)	(0.023)	(0.022)	(0.022)
Income	-0.037	-0.056***	0.027	-0.045	0.018	0.025
	(0.020)	(0.016)	(0.015)	(0.023)	(0.019)	(0.018)
Income- Don't Know	-0.011	-0.054**	-0.095	-0.014	-0.036	0.027
	(0.021)	(0.016)	(0.081)	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.071)
Political Interest	0.080***	0.132***		0.158***	0.108***	
	(0.017)	(0.014)		(0.019)	(0.017)	
Campaign Interest			0.080***			0.094***
			(0.015)			(0.017)
Constant	0.204***	0.176***	0.269***	0.052**	0.139***	0.084***
	(0.019)	(0.015)	(0.018)	(0.020)	(0.018)	(0.020)
Observations	2,967	3,985	4,428	2,894	3,950	3,402
Note:				*p<0.05; **p<0.01, ***p<0.001		

Appendix E. Replication with Group Grievances

Our primary operationalization of identity content with linked fate follows from the items inclusion in the several data sets we consider as well as it indexing a sense of group interdependence. While seen by many as approximating group consciousness (McClain et al 2009), the item itself does not contain any sense of grievances galvanizing a specific approach to politics. The sense of interconnectedness it captures misses political valence.

We thus turn to a separate approach for thinking about consistency by exploring endorsement of racial grievances (Stephens-Dougan et al 2026). Following ideas of polar power and system blame within original conceptualizations of group consciousness (Miller et al 1981; see also Stephens-Dougan et al 2026), we identify items capturing concern with racism, beliefs about the state of racial equality, and structural attributions for racism (see Table A1). While items vary across data sets, years, and groups, thematic content persists. As with our embeddedness and interests measures, we construct this outcome via principal components analyses as a way to create a single metric agnostic to specific weighting choices of items into the composite and varied response scales across items. We then rescale this to run from 0-1 with higher values denoting more grievances – belief that racism is a problem and that it has structural origins and implications.

The parameter estimates in Table E1 offer evidence corroborating the patterns observed using linked fate alone among Black Americans, but variation among Latinos. For Blacks, all estimates for group embeddedness in the variance equation are negative, with all but one (2016 ANES) distinct from 0. For Latinos, we again find a positive and significant coefficient in 2020 but now find negative and significant coefficients in 2016 and 2024. Moving from linked fate alone to racial group grievances shifts our understanding of group cohesion. But considered across elections we see contingency, reinforcing the potential for variability in group meaning – here, across electoral contexts.

That the patterns across operationalizations are consistent for Blacks and inconsistent for Latinos highlights the importance of thinking broadly about identity content. Here, it seems that the cohesion we found for general interconnectedness as indexed by linked fate can also be found in the cohesion in group grievances over structural discrimination and racism's importance. For Latinos, our results suggest we can find more cohesion here on grievances, on concern with racism and the obstacles it presents to advancement, than on a more general sense of interconnectedness.

Table E1. Heteroskedastic Regression of Linked Fate on Group Embeddedness and Individual Interests, and their Interaction

	Black						Latino		
	2016		2020		2024		2016	2020	2024
	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	ANES	CMPS	CMPS	CMPS	CMPS
Group Embeddedness	0.356*	0.130*	0.223*	0.514*	0.592*	0.366*	0.330*	0.144*	0.376*
	(0.061)	(0.026)	(0.023)	(0.049)	(0.070)	(0.026)	(0.033)	(0.021)	(0.046)
Individual Interests	0.272*	0.098*	0.120*	0.168*	0.166*	0.027	-0.017	0.005	-0.116*
	(0.105)	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.041)	(0.057)	(0.023)	(0.020)	(0.019)	(0.036)
Interest in Politics	-0.054	-0.071*	-0.074*	-0.076*	-0.081	-0.055*	-0.039*	0.016	0.001
	(0.049)	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.035)	(0.046)	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.011)	(0.024)
Constant	0.535*	0.545*	0.446*	0.478*	0.400*	0.423*	0.404*	0.518*	0.524*
	(0.064)	(0.017)	(0.013)	(0.037)	(0.053)	(0.018)	(0.035)	(0.019)	(0.038)
Variance Equation									
Group Embeddedness	-0.768	-0.923*	-0.589*	-2.094*	-2.010*	-0.438*	-0.658*	0.345*	-1.182*
	(0.452)	(0.215)	(0.179)	(0.376)	(0.470)	(0.209)	(0.252)	(0.172)	(0.342)
Individual Interests	-0.021	-0.761*	-0.541*	-0.016	0.236	-0.015	0.352*	-0.082	-0.327
	(0.694)	(0.159)	(0.132)	(0.341)	(0.403)	(0.184)	(0.151)	(0.143)	(0.295)
Interest in Politics	0.345	0.451*	0.252*	0.303	0.757*	0.19	0.124	0.182*	0.790*
	(0.363)	(0.112)	(0.093)	(0.272)	(0.319)	(0.117)	(0.113)	(0.087)	(0.171)
Constant	-3.152*	-2.797*	-3.056*	-2.470*	-2.607*	-3.326*	-3.451*	-3.716*	-2.994*
	(0.359)	(0.126)	(0.094)	(0.233)	(0.268)	(0.125)	(0.160)	(0.102)	(0.174)
N	217	2949	582	4117	384	2437	2384	3596	1053

Note: * p < .05. Maximum likelihood regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Demographic covariates included but withheld from table. CMPS years do not align with survey field dates. 2016 ran December 2016 through February 2017, 2020 ran April through August 2021, and 2024 iteration ran May to the beginning of September 2025.

Appendix F. Leave-One-Out Test for PCA

Theoretically, we constructed our measure of group embeddedness using several indicators given our belief that this concept has multiple manifestations. PCA's aim to create a linear composite that maximizes the variance explained across items, however, could give undue influence to one. Consequently, our aim to think about embeddedness generally becomes a story about a narrower band of indicators.

To demonstrate the robustness of our findings we replicate the main analyses but use a leave-one-out approach to construct our PCAs. For each data collection in each year, we estimate PCA scores by dropping one of the component indicators and then estimating the heteroskedastic regression model. We do this iteratively, dropping each indicator one.

Figure F1 shows the results from this analysis. The panels in the top row report the distribution of coefficient estimates for group embeddedness in the variance equation within group and year across definitions of the component. The panels in the top row report the associated z-statistics. Together, the information shows how similar our understanding of the relationship is and whether our confidence in that association being significantly different from 0 would shift.

Altogether, the results show that our conclusions are robust to different choices. All parameter estimates in each year are quite similar, as are all z-scores. We do see fluctuation, but nothing decisive. Consider significance testing. Only 2 z-statistics in models for Black Americans (both in the 2016) ANES would lead us to different decisions about the test's decisiveness. But here the estimated coefficients are quite similar to others, and the smallest of the z-statistics in question is still -1.87. We see 3 z-statistics vary appreciable for Latinos, with 1 in the 2016 ANES and 2 in the 2016 CMPS. In the ANES, we would have clear evidence for the *agreement hypothesis*, not just the directional support we find overall. The 2016 CMPS sees less precise relationships but still directionally consistent (smallest z = 1.62). The coefficient estimates are all similar, too, despite the variation in significance.

Taken together, we see these results as strengthening the conclusions we make in the main text. We have beliefs about the relevance of the several indicators of group embeddedness, and no single indicator appears to drive results. This conclusion is reinforced when considering which specific items, when dropped, alter results. For Black Americans, eliminating personal experiences with discrimination or beliefs about the group's political influence attenuates the relevance of group embeddedness marginally in the 2016 ANES. But these items capture aspects of social and psychological embeddedness in the group whose removal makes little sense theoretically. Similarly, for Latinos, removing racial identity centrality in the 2016 ANES increases the relevance of group embeddedness, but this too makes little sense to select theoretically as caring about the group is an important psychological aspect of embeddedness (Anoll et al 2025), one seen as a precursor to a sense of interdependence or general group consciousness (Miller at al 1981; Leach et al 2008). Similarly, removing the affective attachments people have about their group or perceptions of group discrimination make little sense theoretically when striving to capture psychological embeddedness.

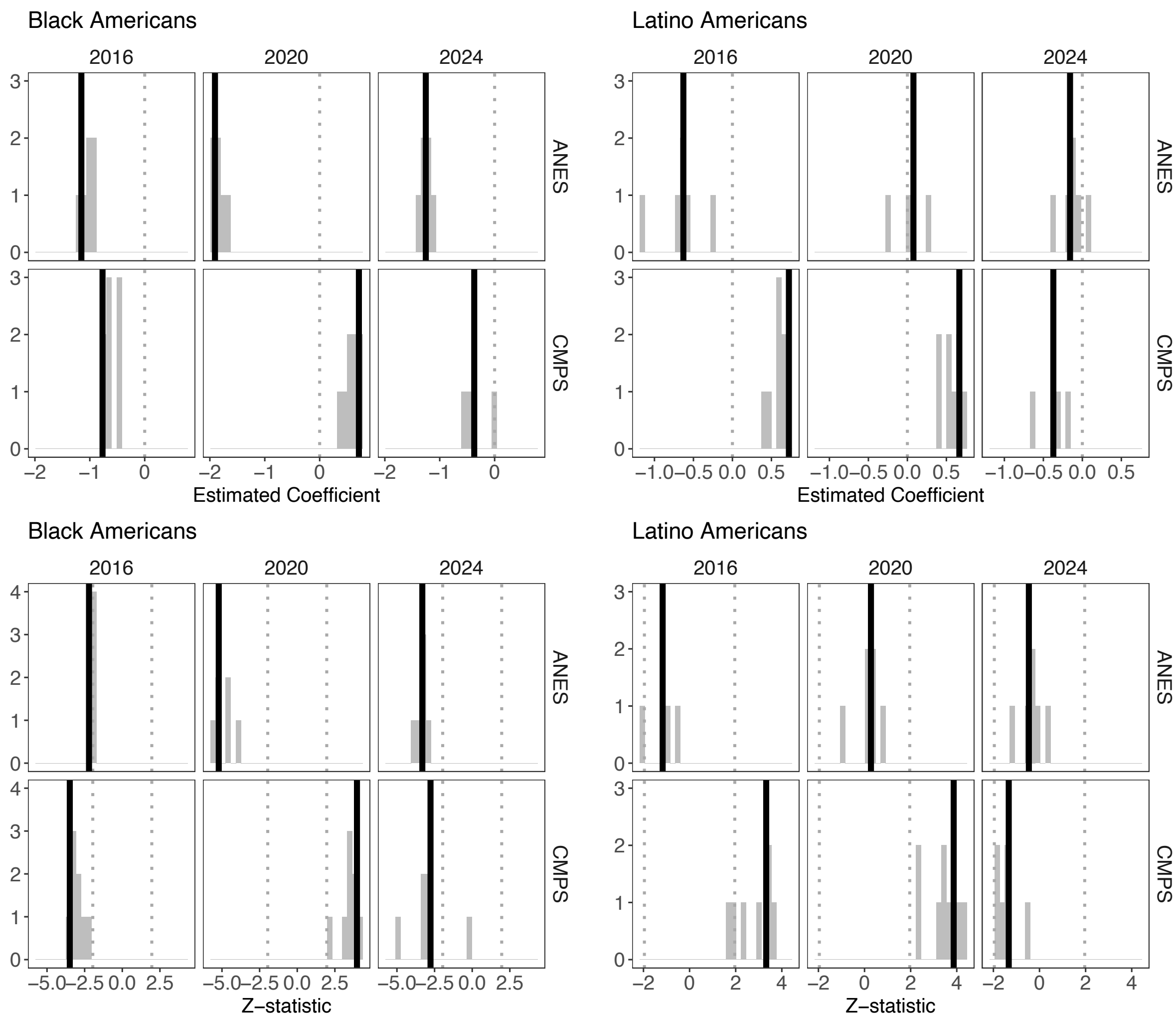

Figure F1. Coefficient estimates and z-statistics for group embeddedness in regression variance equations from iteratively removing embeddedness indicators. Solid vertical lines denote the full measure results reported in Table 2. Vertical dotted lines provide visual references of 0, for coefficient estimates, and ±1.96 for z-scores.

References

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